
Σοφία Σιραχ (*Ecclesiasticus*) ▫ THE WISDOM OF SIRACH (*ECCLESIASTICUS*)

INTRODUCTION

The *Wisdom of Sirach* is also known as *Ecclesiasticus* and *The Wisdom of Jesus Ben Sira*; the former suggests its use as a ‘church book’ in the early Christian community, which accepted it into its canon. The Jewish community, followed by the Reformers, excluded it from the canon. This explains the extraordinary history of its text. The original Hebrew text was lost to the western world from about 400 CE to 1900; the book survived in Greek, Latin, Syriac and other translations. Since about 1900, extensive sections of the Hebrew text have been discovered in various MSS: those of the *Cairo Genizah*, the *Qumran Scrolls*, and the *Masada Corpus*, so that now two thirds of that exists. The translation here is largely based on the Septuagint, with notable omissions and differences from other texts addressed in the footnotes.

Although the book lacks any clear structure, it resembles the Book of Proverbs in many ways. It stresses characteristic wisdom teachings: proper speech, riches and poverty, honesty, diligence, choice of friends, sin and death, retribution and wisdom itself. Unlike Proverbs 10ff, individual maxims are not set apart but are incorporated into smooth-flowing poems of some length (often in accordance with the number of letters in the Hebrew alphabet). The doctrine is surprisingly traditional, almost as if Job and Ecclesiastes have never been written. Ben Sira is aware of the problem of suffering (2:1–6, 11:4, 40:1–10) but he is a firm believer in the justice of divine retribution. God will reward everyone according to one’s deserts (15:11–16:23). There is not intimation of a future life with God in the Hebrew text; rather, all go to Sheol (14:12–19, 38:16–23). This is the usual Hebrew teaching, which understood immortality only in terms of one’s progeny and good name (44:13–15). Traditionally, Wisdom literature never appealed to Israel’s sacred history or Covenant. Ben Sira is an outstanding exception, in view of his ‘Hymn to the Patriarchs’ (Chs 44–50) and his identification of personified wisdom with the Torah or Law (24:23). At the same time, his book belongs definitely to the genre of wisdom literature, with its stress on the lessons of experience and on the ‘fear of the Lord’ (1:11–30, 25:10–11, 40:25–27).

AUTHORSHIP AND DATES

Ben Sira signs his name (50:27), describes his profession (39:1–11) and invites students to his school (51:23). Sometime before 180 BCE and the ensuing Maccabaeen revolt, he committed his wisdom to writing, probably in Jerusalem (see his description in 50:1–24 of Simeon II, who was High Priest from 219–196). Sometime after 132 BCE (see the Prologue), his grandson translated the original Hebrew into Greek. The grandson rightly stresses the profound knowledge that Ben Sira had of Hebrew traditions (‘the Law and the Prophets and the other books’ – already the threefold division of the Hebrew Bible was in the process of formation).

The ‘TheoDoor’ file for this book has yet to be completed; we have now completed the encoding of the Hebrew text and are now working through this parallel text, adding appropriate footnotes. We present here, the Prologue thru Chapter 16 as a ‘preview’.

Σοφία Σιραχ - Προλογος

¹ Πολλῶν καὶ μεγάλων ἡμῖν διὰ τοῦ νόμου καὶ τῶν προφητῶν ² καὶ τῶν ἄλλων τῶν κατ' αὐτοὺς ἠκολουθηκότων δεδομένων, ³ ὑπὲρ ὧν θεὸν ἐστὶν ἐπαινεῖν τὸν Ἰσραὴλ παιδείας καὶ σοφίας, ⁴ καὶ ὥς οὐ μόνον αὐτοὺς τοὺς ἀναγινώσκοντας θεὸν ἐστὶν ἐπιστήμονας γίνεσθαι, ⁵ ἀλλὰ καὶ τοῖς ἐκτὸς δύνασθαι τοὺς φιλομαθοῦντας χρη σίμους εἶναι ⁶ καὶ λέγοντας καὶ γράφοντας, ⁷ ὁ πάππος μου Ἰησοῦς ἐπὶ πλεῖον ἑαυτὸν δοῦς ⁸ εἰς τε τὴν τοῦ νόμου ⁹ καὶ τῶν προφητῶν ¹⁰ καὶ τῶν ἄλλων πατρίων βιβλίων ἀνάγνωσιν ¹¹ καὶ ἐν τούτοις ἱκανὴν ἔξιν περιποιησάμενος ¹² προήχθη καὶ αὐτὸς συγγράψαι τι τῶν εἰς παιδείαν καὶ σοφίαν ἀνηκόντων, ¹³ ὅπως οἱ

WISDOM OF SIRACH – PROLOGUE

¹ Many and great lessons have been passed on to us by the Law, the Prophets, ² and the other writers succeeding them, ³ in consequence of which Israel must be commended for learning and wisdom. ⁴ Furthermore, it is a duty, not only to acquire learning by reading, ⁵ but also, once having acquired it, to make oneself of use to those who are outside ⁶ by what one can say or write. ⁷ My grandfather Jesus, having long devoted himself to the reading ⁸ of the Law, ⁹ and the Prophets ¹⁰ and other books of the Fathers ¹¹ and, having become very learned in them, ¹² himself decided to write something on learning and wisdom, ¹³ so that people who

WISDOM OF SIRACH PROLOGUE

- ¹ This foreword by the Greek translator is not strictly a part of the book and is not usually considered canonical. On the 3 divisions of the Hebrew Bible, see #1M 12:9.
- ² At the end of this verse, the NJB includes the words, “have passed on to us great lessons,” from the beginning of v. 1.
- ³ The WEBBE has ‘given praise’ in place of ‘commended’.
- ⁴ In place of ‘acquire learning’, the WEBBE has ‘become skilful’.
- ⁵ The NJB has ‘people’ in place of ‘those who are’.
- ⁶ For this verse, the WEBBE reads, “both by speaking and writing.”
- ⁷ ‘Jesus’ here refers to Jesus ben Sira, the author of the book.
- ⁸ An exact English translation for this short verse is difficult.
- ⁹ The NJB lacks the opening ‘and’.
- ¹⁰ The WEBBE has ‘our fathers’ in place of ‘the Fathers’.
- ¹¹ For this verse, the WEBBE reads, “and having gained great familiarity with them.”
- ¹² Before ‘learning’, the NJB adds ‘the subjects of’.
- ¹³ The NJB has ‘wanted to learn’ in place of ‘love learning’, here following the WEBBE.

φιλομαθεῖς καὶ τούτων ἔνοχοι γενόμενοι ¹⁴ πολλῶ ἄλλον ἐπιπροσθῶσιν διὰ τῆς ἐννόμου βιώσεως.

¹⁵ Παρακέκλησθε οὖν ¹⁶ μετ' εὐνοίας καὶ προσοχῆς ¹⁷ τὴν ἀνάγνωσιν ποιῆσθαι ¹⁸ καὶ συγγνώμην ἔχειν ¹⁹ ἐφ' οἷς ἂν δοκῶμεν ²⁰ τῶν κατὰ τὴν ἐρμηνείαν πεφιλοπονημένων τισὶν τῶν λέξεων ἀδυναμεῖν. ²¹ οὐ γὰρ ἰσοδυναμεῖ ²² αὐτὰ ἐν ἑαυτοῖς Εβραϊστὶ λεγόμενα καὶ ὅταν μεταχθῇ εἰς ἑτέραν γλῶσσαν. ²³ οὐ μόνον δὲ ταῦτα, ²⁴ ἀλλὰ καὶ αὐτὸς ὁ νόμος καὶ αἱ προφητεῖαι ²⁵ καὶ τὰ λοιπὰ τῶν βιβλίων ²⁶ οὐ μικρὰν ἔχει τὴν διαφορὰν ἐν ἑαυτοῖς λεγόμενα.

²⁷ Ἐν γὰρ τῷ ὀγδόῳ καὶ τριακοστῷ ἔτει ἐπὶ τοῦ Εὐεργέτου βασιλέως ²⁸ παραγεννηθεὶς εἰς Αἴγυπτον καὶ συγχρονίσας

love learning might, by accepting these disciplines, ¹⁴ learn how better to live according to the Law.

¹⁵ Pray then, ¹⁶ with favour and care, ¹⁷ read this book ¹⁸ and pardon us ¹⁹ in those places where, despite our efforts to translate, we may seem ²⁰ to fail to give a good rendering of some phrases; ²¹ for, there is no equivalent ²² for things originally written in Hebrew when translating them into another language; ²³ not only this, ²⁴ but the Law itself and the Prophets ²⁵ and the rest of books ²⁶ differ considerably in translation from what appears in the original text.

²⁷ It was in the thirty-eighth year of the late King Euergetes ²⁸ that, coming to Egypt and remaining here for some time,

¹⁴ For this verse, the WEBBE reads, "might make progress much more by living according to the law."

¹⁵ For this verse, here (literally) following the LXX, the NJB has, "You are therefore asked."

¹⁶ The NJB swaps the translations for vv. 16 & 17.

¹⁷ A more literal translation of 'this book' is 'what is written'.

¹⁸ The NJB has 'show indulgence' in place of 'pardon us'.

¹⁹ In place of 'despite', the NJB has 'notwithstanding'.

²⁰ The NJB splits this verse, ending, "of this ²¹ or that expression."

²¹ The NJB includes this verse as part of v. 22 (but cf. #20).

²² Before 'translating', the NJB adds 'it is a question of'.

²³ The literal translation of 'this' is 'these'.

²⁴ The NJB lacks the opening 'but', here following the Greek text (ἀλλὰ).

²⁵ In place of 'rest of', the NJB has 'other'.

²⁶ For 'differ considerably', the WEBBE has 'have no small difference'.

²⁷ This king was probably Ptolemy VII Euergetes Physcon (170–117 BCE); the date would therefore be 123 BCE.

²⁸ The WEBBE has 'coming to Egypt' at the start of v. 27.

²⁹ εὐρὼν οὐ μικρᾷς παιδείας ἀφόμοιον ³⁰ ἀναγκαιότατον
ἐθέμην καὶ αὐτός τινα προσενέγκασθαι σπουδὴν καὶ
φιλοπονίαν τοῦ μεθερμηνεῦσαι τήνδε τὴν βίβλον ³¹ πολλὴν
ἀγρυπνίαν καὶ ἐπιστήμην προσενεγκάμενος ³² ἐν τῷ
διαστήματι τοῦ χρόνου ³³ πρὸς τὸ ἐπὶ πέρας ἀγαγόντα τὸ
βιβλίον ἐκδόσθαι ³⁴ καὶ τοῖς ἐν τῇ παροικίᾳ βουλομένοις
φιλομαθεῖν ³⁵ προκατασκευαζομένους τὰ ἥδη ³⁶ ἐννόμως
βιοτεύειν.

²⁹ and finding a copy for no little instruction, ³⁰ I became
convinced of an immediate duty to apply myself in my turn
with labour and diligence to translate this book; ³¹ and I
spent much time and learning on it ³² in the course of this
period, ³³ to complete the work and to publish the book ³⁴ for
the benefit of those too who, domiciled abroad, desire to
study, ³⁵ to reform their behaviour in advance, ³⁶ to live as the
Law requires.

²⁹ According to the translation used here (others have ‘*opportunity*’ in place of ‘*copy*’), Ben Sira, in offering his grandfather’s book to the Greek public, intends to please a community already cultivated and worthy of enrichment.

³⁰ The NJB has ‘*the book that follows*’ in place of ‘*this book*’.

³¹ In place of ‘*time and learning*’, the WEBBE has ‘*watchfulness and skill*’.

³² For ‘*in the course of this period*’, the WEBBE has ‘*in that space of time*’.

³³ The WEBBE has ‘*bring the book to an end*’ in place of ‘*complete the book*’.

³⁴ In place of ‘*domiciled abroad*’, the WEBBE has ‘*in the land of their travels*’.

³⁵ The NJB lacks ‘*in advance*’, here following the WEBBE.

³⁶ The NJB includes this verse as part of v. 35.

Σοφία Σιραχ Ι

- ¹ Πᾶσα σοφία παρὰ κυρίου καὶ
μετ' αὐτοῦ ἐστὶν εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα.
- ² ἄμμον θαλασσῶν καὶ σταγόνας ὕετοῦ
καὶ ἡμέρας αἰῶνος τίς ἐξαριθμήσει;
- ³ ὕψος οὐρανοῦ καὶ πλάτος γῆς
καὶ ἄβυσσον καὶ σοφίαν τίς ἐξιχνιάσει;
- ⁴ προτέρα πάντων ἔκτισται σοφία
καὶ σύνεσις φρονήσεως ἐξ αἰῶνος.
- ⁵ *Fons sapientiae verbum Dei in excelsis,
et ingressus illius mandata aeterna.*
- ⁶ ῥίζα σοφίας τίνι ἀπεκαλύφθη;
καὶ τὰ πανουργεύματα αὐτῆς τίς ἔγνω;
- ⁷ *disciplina sapientiae cui revelata est et manifestata?
et multiplicationem ingressus illius quis intellexit?*
- ⁸ εἷς ἐστὶν σοφός, φοβερός σφόδρα,
καθήμενος ἐπὶ τοῦ θρόνου αὐτοῦ.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 1

- ¹ All wisdom comes from the Lord and
she is with him forever.
- ² The sands of the sea, the drops of rain
and the days of eternity – who can count them?
- ³ The height of the sky, the breadth of the earth
and the abyss and wisdom – who can explore them?
- ⁴ Wisdom was created before everything
prudent understanding from remotest ages.
- ⁵ *The source of wisdom is the word of God on high;
and her paths are the eternal commandments.*
- ⁶ To whom has the root of wisdom been revealed?
Her resourceful ways, who knows them?
- ⁷ *To whom was the knowledge of wisdom manifested?
And who has understood the abundance of her ways?*
- ⁸ One only is wise, terrible indeed,
seated on his throne, the Lord.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 1

- ¹ This first chapter is a series of variations on the themes enunciated at the beginning of Proverbs. The term 'Lord' (Kyrios) is commonly used in the LXX to render the name *Yahweh*. Ben Sira's translator uses it very frequently, even to render the other divine names.
- ² Vv. 2-3 illustrate the impossibility of fathoming the depths of divine wisdom (18:4-7, Rm 11:33).
- ³ In place of 'the abyss and wisdom' (here following the LXX and NRSV), the NJB, following the Vg (*profundum abyssi*), has 'the depth of the abyss'.
- ⁴ Compare Pr 8:22-31.
- ⁵ This verse, in the WEBBE & NJB only as a footnote, is not in the LXX; it is, however, in the Vg and the MSS known as *Greek 248*.
- ⁶ Only with God is wisdom to be found, yet God has bestowed her upon all the living – especially upon those who love him (Israel, v. 10)
- ⁷ This verse follows the *Syro-Hexaplar* text, *Greek 248*, and the Vg (see #5); it is present in the WEBBE and NJB only as a footnote.
- ⁸ The author emphasises the uniqueness and transcendence of God.

⁹ κύριος αὐτὸς ἔκτισεν αὐτὴν
καὶ εἶδεν καὶ ἐξηρίθμησεν αὐτὴν
καὶ ἐξέχεεν αὐτὴν ἐπὶ πάντα τὰ ἔργα αὐτοῦ,
¹⁰ μετὰ πάσης σαρκὸς κατὰ τὴν δόσιν αὐτοῦ,
καὶ ἐχορήγησεν αὐτὴν τοῖς ἀγαπῶσιν αὐτόν.
¹¹ Φόβος κυρίου δόξα καὶ καύχημα
καὶ εὐφροσύνη καὶ στέφανος ἀγαλλιάματος.
¹² φόβος κυρίου τέρψει καρδίαν
καὶ δώσει εὐφροσύνην καὶ χαρὰν καὶ μακροημέρευσιν.
¹³ τῷ φοβουμένῳ τὸν κύριον εὖ ἔσται ἐπ' ἐσχάτων,
καὶ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ τελευτῆς αὐτοῦ εὐλογηθήσεται.
¹⁴ Ἀρχὴ σοφίας φοβεῖσθαι τὸν κύριον,
καὶ μετὰ πιστῶν ἐν μήτρᾳ συνεκτίσθη αὐτοῖς.
¹⁵ μετὰ ἀνθρώπων θεμέλιον αἰῶνος ἐνόσσευσεν
καὶ μετὰ τοῦ σπέρματος αὐτῶν ἐμπιστευθήσεται.
¹⁶ πλησμονὴ σοφίας φοβεῖσθαι τὸν κύριον
καὶ μεθύσκει αὐτοὺς ἀπὸ τῶν καρπῶν αὐτῆς·

⁹ It was he who created,
inspected and weighed her up,
and then poured her out on all his works –
¹⁰ as much to each living creature as he chose –
bestowing her on those who love him.
¹¹ The fear of the Lord is glory and exultation,
happiness and a crown of joyfulness.
¹² The fear of Lord gladdens the heart,
giving happiness, joy and long life.
¹³ For those who fear the Lord, all will end well:
on their dying day, they will be blessed.
¹⁴ The basis of wisdom is to fear the Lord;
she was created with the faithful in the womb.
¹⁵ She has made a nest in men, an age-old foundation,
and to their descendants will she faithfully cling.
¹⁶ The fullness of wisdom is to fear the Lord;
she intoxicates them with her fruits.

⁹ After 'created', the Vg adds 'in the Holy Spirit' (*in Spiritu Sancto*), which is a Christian interpolation.

¹⁰ At the end of this verse, some MSS add, "Love of the Lord is glorious wisdom; to those to whom he appears he apportions her, that they may see him."

¹¹ The 'fear of the Lord', for a Jew, merely means religion or piety.

¹² After this verse, some MSS add: "The fear of the Lord is a gift from the Lord; also, for love he makes firm paths."

¹³ Here, the Vg adds 2 verses: ¹⁴ *Dilectio Dei honorabilis sapientia:*

¹⁵ *quibus autem apparuerit in visu diligunt eam in visione,*
et in agnitione magnalium suorum.

¹⁴ *The love of God is a wisdom worthy of honour,*

¹⁵ *but those to whom he has appeared love him*
and contemplate him by proclaiming his great works.

¹⁴ Compare Pr 1:7, 9:10, Job 28:28, Ps 111:10.

¹⁵ The WEBBE has 'eternal' in place of 'age-old'.

¹⁶ In place of 'intoxicates them', the WEBBE has 'inebriates men'.

¹⁷ πάντα τὸν οἶκον αὐτῶν ἐμπλήσει ἐπιθυμημάτων
καὶ τὰ ἀποδοχεῖα ἀπὸ τῶν γεννημάτων αὐτῆς.
¹⁸ στέφανος σοφίας φόβος κυρίου
ἀναθάλλων εἰρήνην καὶ υἱάειαν ἰάσεως.
¹⁹ καὶ εἶδεν καὶ ἐξηρίθμησεν αὐτήν,
ἐπιστήμην καὶ γνῶσιν συνέσεως ἐξώμβρησεν
καὶ δόξαν κρατούντων αὐτῆς ἀνύψωσεν.
²⁰ ῥίζα σοφίας φοβεῖσθαι τὸν κύριον,
καὶ οἱ κλάδοι αὐτῆς μακροημέρευσις.
²¹ *Timor Domini expellit peccatum:*
²² Οὐ δυνήσεται θυμὸς ἄδικος δικαιωθῆναι·
ἡ γὰρ ῥοπή τοῦ θυμοῦ αὐτοῦ πτώσις αὐτοῦ.
²³ ἕως καιροῦ ἀνδέξεται μακρόθυμος,
καὶ ὕστερον αὐτῷ ἀναδώσει εὐφροσύνη·
²⁴ ἕως καιροῦ κρύψει τοὺς λόγους αὐτοῦ,
καὶ χεῖλη πολλῶν ἐκδιηγῆσεται σύνεσιν αὐτοῦ.

¹⁷ She fills their entire house with treasures
and their storerooms with her produce.
¹⁸ The crown of wisdom is to fear the Lord:
she makes peace and health flourish.
¹⁹ The Lord has seen and assessed her,
he has showered down knowledge and intelligence
and exalted the renown of those who possess her.
²⁰ The root of wisdom is to fear the Lord
and her branches are longevity.
²¹ *The fear of the Lord drives away sin.*
²² Unjust anger cannot be justified;
for, his rage tips the scales to his downfall.
²³ A patient man puts up with things for a season
but his joy will break out in the end.
²⁴ He will hide his words until the right moment,
and many a lip will affirm how wise he is.

¹⁷ Some MSS have 'her' in place of both occurrences of 'their'.

¹⁸ After this verse, some MSS add: "Both are gifts of God for peace; glory opens out for those who love him. He saw her and took her measure."

¹⁹ The WEBBE has 'honour' in place of 'renown'.

²⁰ In place of 'longevity', the NJB has 'long life' and the WEBBE has 'length of days'.

²¹ This verse follows the Syro-Hexaplar, Vg, and Greek 248 (see #5); it is given in the WEBBE & NJB only as a footnote.

The Vg adds another verse: ²⁶ *In thesauris sapientiae intellectus*

et scientiae religiositas:

execratio autem peccatoribus sapientia.

²⁶ *In the treasures of wisdom is understanding*

and piety of knowledge.

but wisdom is abhorred by sinners.

²² The NJB lacks the 1st instance of 'his' and, in place of the 2nd, has 'one's'.

²³ In place of 'for a season', the NJB has 'until the time is right'.

²⁴ The NJB has 'keeps his thoughts to himself' in place of 'will hide his words'.

²⁵ Ἐν θησαυροῖς σοφίας παραβολαὶ ἐπιστήμης,
 βδέλυγμα δὲ ἁμαρτωλῷ θεοσέβεια.
²⁶ ἐπιθυμήσας σοφίαν διατήρησον ἐντολάς,
 καὶ κύριος χορηγήσει σοὶ αὐτήν.
²⁷ σοφία γὰρ καὶ παιδεία φόβος κυρίου,
 καὶ ἡ εὐδοκία αὐτοῦ πίστις καὶ πραότης.
²⁸ μὴ ἀπειθήσης φόβῳ κυρίου
 καὶ μὴ προσέλθῃς αὐτῷ ἐν καρδίᾳ δισσῇ.
²⁹ μὴ ὑποκριθῇς ἐν στόμασιν ἀνθρώπων
 καὶ ἐν τοῖς χεῖλεσίν σου πρόσεχε.
³⁰ μὴ ἐξύψου σεαυτόν, ἵνα μὴ πέσης
 καὶ ἐπαγάγῃς τῇ ψυχῇ σου ἄτιμίαν,
 καὶ ἀποκαλύψει κύριος τὰ κρυπτὰ σου
 καὶ ἐν μέσῳ συναγωγῆς καταβαλεῖ σε,
 ὅτι οὐ προσῆλθες φόβῳ κυρίου
 καὶ ἡ καρδία σου πλήρης δόλου.

²⁵ In Wisdom's treasures are maxims of knowledge;
 but the sinner holds piety in abhorrence.
²⁶ If you desire wisdom, keep the commandments,
 and the Lord will bestow it on you.
²⁷ For, the fear of the Lord is wisdom and instruction
 and what pleases him is faith and humility.
²⁸ Do not stand out against fear of the Lord;
 do not come to him with a double heart.
²⁹ Do not be a hypocrite before others;
 keep watch over your lips.
³⁰ Do not exalt yourself, for fear you fall
 and cover yourself in disgrace.
 For, the Lord would then reveal you secrets
 and overthrow you before the whole community,
 for not having practised fear of the Lord
 and for having a heart full of deceit.

²⁵ The WEBBE has 'wise sayings' in place of 'maxims of knowledge'.

²⁶ For Ben Sira, wisdom and observance of the Law go together (19:20, cf. Qo 12:13). Here, wisdom is the reward of observance.

²⁷ For 'faith and humility', the NJB has 'faithfulness and gentleness'.

²⁸ The NJB has 'practice it' in place of 'come to him'.

²⁹ The literal translation of 'others' is 'human beings' (following the *Textus Receptus*); the LXX has 'in the mouth (of the world)'.

³⁰ In place of 'exalt yourself', the NJB has 'grow too high and mighty'.

Σοφία Σιραχ 2

- 1 Τέκνον, εἰ προσέρχῃ δουλεύειν κυρίῳ,
ἐτοίμασον τὴν ψυχὴν σου εἰς πειρασμόν·
- 2 εὐθυον τὴν καρδίαν σου καὶ καρτέρησον
καὶ μὴ σπεύσῃς ἐν καιρῷ ἐπαγωγῆς·
- 3 κολλήθητι αὐτῷ καὶ μὴ ἀποστῆς,
ἵνα αὐξηθῇς ἐπ' ἐσχάτων σου.
- 4 πᾶν, ὃ ἐὰν ἐπαχθῇ σοι, δέξαι
καὶ ἐν ἀλλάγμασιν ταπεινώσεώς σου μακροθύμησον·
- 5 ὅτι ἐν πυρὶ δοκιμάζεται χρυσὸς
καὶ ἄνθρωποι δεκτοὶ ἐν καμίνῳ ταπεινώσεως.
- 6 πίστευσον αὐτῷ, καὶ ἀντιλήμψεταιί σου·
εὐθυον τὰς ὁδοὺς σου καὶ ἔλπισον ἐπ' αὐτόν.
- 7 Οἱ φοβούμενοι τὸν κύριον, ἀναμείνατε τὸ ἔλεος αὐτοῦ
καὶ μὴ ἐκκλίνετε, ἵνα μὴ πέσητε.
- 8 οἱ φοβούμενοι κύριον, πιστεύσατε αὐτῷ,
καὶ οὐ μὴ πταίση ὁ μισθὸς ὑμῶν.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 2

- 1 My child, if you aspire to serve the Lord,
prepare yourself for an ordeal.
- 2 Be sincere of heart, be steadfast,
and don't make haste in time of calamity.
- 3 Cling to him and do not leave him,
so that you may be honoured at the end of your days.
- 4 Accept whatever happens to you
and be patient when you suffer humiliation.
- 5 For, gold is tested in the fire,
and the chosen in the furnace of humiliation.
- 6 Trust him and he will uphold you,
follow a straight path and hope in him.
- 7 You who fear the Lord, wait for his mercy;
do not turn aside, lest you fall.
- 8 You who fear the Lord, trust him,
and you will not be robbed of your reward.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 2

- 1 The NRSV has 'testing' in place of 'an ordeal'. The fear of God in times of ordeal is a recurrent OT theme, particularly in the Psalms.
- 2 For the 2nd line, here following the WEBBE, the NRSV has, "and do not be alarmed when disaster comes."
- 3 The WEBBE has 'increased' in place of 'honoured'.
- 4 For the 2nd line, here following the WEBBE, the NRSV has, "and in the uncertainties of your humble state, be patient."
- 5 Some MSS add: "in sickness and poverty, put your trust in him."
- 6 The WEBBE has 'acceptable men' place of 'the chosen'.
- 7 In place of 'lest', the NRSV has 'for fear'.
- 8 Note that the Greek text lacks the word τὸν before κύριον in the 1st line, here; cf. v. 7.

⁹ οἱ φοβούμενοι κύριον, ἐλπίσατε εἰς ἀγαθὰ
καὶ εἰς εὐφροσύνην αἰῶνος καὶ ἔλεος.
¹⁰ ἐμβλέψατε εἰς ἀρχαίας γενεάς καὶ ἴδετε·
τίς ἐνεπίστευσεν κυρίῳ καὶ κατησχύνθη;
ἢ τίς ἐνέμεινεν τῷ φόβῳ αὐτοῦ καὶ ἐγκατελείφθη;
ἢ τίς ἐπεκαλέσατο αὐτόν, καὶ ὑπερεῖδεν αὐτόν;
¹¹ διότι οἰκτίρων καὶ ἐλεήμων ὁ κύριος
καὶ ἀφίησιν ἁμαρτίας καὶ σώζει ἐν καιρῷ θλίψεως.
¹² Οὐαὶ καρδίαις δειλαῖς καὶ χερσὶν παρειμέναις
καὶ ἁμαρτωλῷ ἐπιβαίνοντι ἐπὶ δύο τρίβους.
¹³ οὐαὶ καρδίᾳ παρειμένῃ, ὅτι οὐ πιστεύει·
διὰ τοῦτο οὐ σκεπασθήσεται.
¹⁴ οὐαὶ ὑμῖν τοῖς ἀπολωλεκόσιν τὴν ὑπομονήν·
καὶ τί ποιήσετε ὅταν ἐπισκέπτηται ὁ κύριος;
¹⁵ οἱ φοβούμενοι κύριον οὐκ ἀπειθήσουσιν ῥημάτων αὐτοῦ,
καὶ οἱ ἀγαπῶντες αὐτόν
συντηρήσουσιν τὰς ὁδοὺς αὐτοῦ.

⁹ You who fear the Lord, hope for his good gifts,
everlasting joy and mercy.
¹⁰ Look at the generations of old and see:
who ever trusted in the Lord and was put to shame?
Or who ever, steadfastly fearing him, was forsaken?
Or who ever was called to him and was ignored?
¹¹ For, the Lord is compassionate and merciful,
he forgives sins and saves in the time of affliction.
¹² Woe to fearful hearts and listless hands,
and to the sinner who treads two paths.
¹³ Woe to the faint heart! For, it doesn't believe;
therefore, it won't be defended.
¹⁴ Woe to you who have lost the strength to endure;
what will you do at the Lord's visitation?
¹⁵ Those who fear the Lord do not disdain his words,
and those who love him
will keep his ways.

⁹ 'Joy' here means in this life, not in the next. Some MSS add: "For his reward is an everlasting gift with joy."

¹⁰ Israel's history shows the efficacy of trust in God, who is 'compassionate and merciful' (v. 11, see Ex 34:6-7, Ps 103:8-9, Jon 4:2). In the 3rd line, the NRSV has 'the Lord' in place of 'him', here following the LXX (and the NJB).

¹¹ The NRSV has 'distress' in place of 'affliction'.

¹² The author is seemingly commending resistance under persecution; he is condemning apostasy, even if only outward (second line, v. 15; cf. 2M 6:21-28).

¹³ For this verse, here following the WEBBE, the NRSV reads, "Woe to the listless heart that has no faith; for such will have no protection."

¹⁴ The WEBBE has 'your patience' in place of 'the strength to endure'.

¹⁵ A more literal translation for 'words' is 'speech'.

¹⁶ οἱ φοβούμενοι κύριον ζητήσουσιν εὐδοκίαν αὐτοῦ,
καὶ οἱ ἀγαπῶντες αὐτὸν ἐμπλησθήσονται τοῦ νόμου.
¹⁷ οἱ φοβούμενοι κύριον ἐτοιμάσουσιν καρδίας αὐτῶν
καὶ ἐνώπιον αὐτοῦ ταπεινώσουσιν τὰς ψυχὰς αὐτῶν.
¹⁸ ἐμπεσούμεθα εἰς χεῖρας κυρίου
καὶ οὐκ εἰς χεῖρας ἀνθρώπων·
ὥς γὰρ ἡ μεγαλωσύνη αὐτοῦ,
οὕτως καὶ τὸ ἔλεος αὐτοῦ.

¹⁶ Those who fear the Lord do their best to please him,
and those who love him will be satisfied in the Law.
¹⁷ Those who fear the Lord keep their hearts prepared
and humble themselves in his presence.
¹⁸ Let us fall into the hands of the Lord,
but not into the hands of mortals;
For, as great as his majesty is,
so also is his mercy,
and equal to his name are his works.

¹⁶ Ben Sira does not oppose love to obedience; he identifies them. Love is disinterested; hope of reward is merely a secondary consideration. This attitude is characteristic of Ben Sira but is found elsewhere in Jewish thought. See, for example, *Pirke Abot*, 1:3: “Do not be like slaves who serve their master for the sake of the reward. Be like slaves who serve their master without looking for reward.”

¹⁷ See 1S 24:14 and 1Ch 21:13.

¹⁸ The last line in the English text follows the *Peshitta* and *NRSV*; it is not present in the *LXX*, *Vg*, the *WEBBE*, or *NJB*.

Σοφία Σιραχ 3

- 1 Ἐμοῦ τοῦ πατρὸς ἀκούσατε, τέκνα,
καὶ οὕτως ποιήσατε, ἵνα σωθῇτε·
- 2 ὁ γὰρ κύριος ἐδόξασεν πατέρα ἐπὶ τέκνοις
καὶ κρίσιν μητρὸς ἐστερέωσεν ἐφ' υἱοῖς.
- 3 ὁ τιμῶν πατέρα ἐξιλάσκειται ἁμαρτίας,
4 καὶ ὡς ὁ ἀποθησαυρίζων ὁ δοξάζων
μητέρα αὐτοῦ.
- 5 ὁ τιμῶν πατέρα εὐφρανθήσεται ὑπὸ τέκνων
καὶ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ προσευχῆς αὐτοῦ εἰσακουσθήσεται.
- 6 ὁ δοξάζων πατέρα μακροημερεύσει,
καὶ ὁ εἰσακούων κυρίου ἀναπαύσει μητέρα αὐτοῦ·
- 7 καὶ ὡς δεσπόταις δουλεύσει ἐν τοῖς γεννήσασιν αὐτόν.
- 8 ἐν ἔργῳ καὶ λόγῳ τίμα τὸν πατέρα σου,
ἵνα ἐπέλθῃ σοι εὐλογία παρ' αὐτοῦ·
- 9 εὐλογία γὰρ πατρὸς στηρίζει οἶκους τέκνων,
κατάρρα δὲ μητρὸς ἐκρίζοι θεμέλια.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 3

- 1 Children, listen to me; for, I am your father;
do what I tell you and so be safe.
- 2 For, the Lord honours a father above his children
and confirms the rights of a mother over her sons.
- 3 Whoever respects his father atones for sins,
4 and whoever respects his mother is as one
amassing treasure.
- 5 He who respects his father will have joy with children;
and the day he prays for help, he will be heard.
- 6 Long life comes to anyone who honours his father;
and those who honour their mother obey the Lord.
- 7 Such a one serves parents as also his masters.
- 8 Respect your father in deed as well as word,
so a blessing may come on you from him.
- 9 For, a father's blessing makes his children's house firm,
while a mother's curse uproots its foundations.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 3

- 1 Ben Sira teaches that the keeping of the commandment to honour one's parents (Ex 20:12) atones for sins (vv. 3, 14–15).
- 2 In place of 'confirms the rights', the WEBBE has 'has confirmed the judgement'.
- 3 For this verse, the WEBBE has a separate sentence, "He who honours his father will make atonement for sins."
- 4 For 'respects', the WEBBE has 'gives glory to'.
- 5 For the 2nd line, the WEBBE has "He will be heard in the day of his prayer." The NJB lacks the opening conjunction.
- 6 Some MSS have 'comfort' in place of 'honour' in the 2nd line.
- 7 Some MSS precede this verse with: "He who fears the Lord honours his father." The NJB has the conjectural 'the Lord' in place of 'his masters'.
- 8 The WEBBE opens with 'Honour' in place of 'Respect'.
- 9 For 'uproots', here following the WEBBE, the NJB has 'tears down'.

¹⁰ μὴ δοξάζου ἐν ἀτιμίᾳ πατρός σου,
οὐ γάρ ἐστὶν σοι δόξα πατρὸς ἀτιμίας·
¹¹ ἢ γὰρ δόξα ἀνθρώπου ἐκ τιμῆς πατρὸς αὐτοῦ,
καὶ ὄνειδος τέκνοις μήτηρ ἐν ἀδοξίᾳ.
¹² τέκνον, ἀντιλαβοῦ ἐν γήρᾳ πατρός σου
καὶ μὴ λυπήσῃς αὐτὸν ἐν τῇ ζωῇ αὐτοῦ·
¹³ καὶ ἀπολείπη σύνεσιν, συγγνώμην ἔχε
καὶ μὴ ἀτιμάσῃς αὐτὸν ἐν πάσῃ ἰσχύϊ σου.
¹⁴ ἔλεημοσύνη γὰρ πατρὸς οὐκ ἐπιλησθήσεται
καὶ ἀντὶ ἁμαρτιῶν προσανοικοδομηθήσεται σοι.
¹⁵ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ θλίψεώς σου ἀναμνησθήσεταιί σου·
ὥς εὐδία ἐπὶ παγετῷ,
οὕτως ἀναλυθήσονται σου αἱ ἁμαρτίαι.
¹⁶ ὥς βλάσφημος ὁ ἐγκαταλιπὼν πατέρα,
καὶ κεκατηραμένος ὑπὸ κυρίου ὁ παροργίζων
μητέρα αὐτοῦ.
¹⁷ Τέκνον, ἐν πραύτητι τὰ ἔργα σου διέξαγε,
καὶ ὑπὸ ἀνθρώπου δεκτοῦ ἀγαπηθήσῃ.

¹⁰ Do not glorify yourself in your father's dishonour;
for, your father's dishonour is no glory to you.
¹¹ For, the glory of a man is from the honour of his father
and a mother in dishonour is a disgrace to her children.
¹² My child, support your father in his old age;
do not grieve him during his life.
¹³ Even if his mind should fail, show him sympathy;
do not despise him in your health and strength.
¹⁴ For, kindness to a father will not be forgotten
but will serve as reparation for your sins.
¹⁵ On your own day of ordeal, God will remember you;
like frost in sunshine,
so your sins will also melt away.
¹⁶ Whoever deserts a father is just like a blasphemer,
and whoever angers a mother is
accursed of the Lord.
¹⁷ My child, be gentle in carrying out your business,
and you will be better loved than a lavish giver.

¹⁰ In place of 'in your father's dishonour', the NJB has 'by dishonouring your father'.

¹¹ For the 1st line, the NJB reads, "One's own honour derives from the respect shown to his father."

¹² The WEBBE has 'son' in place of 'child', here following the Greek (τέκνον) and the NJB.

¹³ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads 'do not dishonour him all the days of his life' (ואל תכלים אותו כל ימי חייו).

¹⁴ 'Kindness' literally translates as 'righteousness', which came to be centred in almsgiving as the characteristic sign (3:10–4:6, 7:10, 29:8–13, Tb 14:10–11).

¹⁵ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' ends, 'as heat upon frost, to put an end to your iniquity' (כחס על כפור להשבית עונך).

¹⁶ The NJB has 'distresses' in place of 'angers'. For 'accursed of the Lord', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'angers his Creator'.

¹⁷ For 'gentle', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'humble' (); 'lavish giver' (literally, 'giver of presents') follows the Cairo Genizah; the LXX has 'agreeable'.

¹⁸ ὅσω μέγας εἶ, τοσούτῳ ταπεινῶς σεαυτόν,
καὶ ἔναντι κυρίου εὐρήσεις χάριν.
...
²⁰ ὅτι μεγάλη ἡ δυναστεία τοῦ κυρίου
καὶ ὑπὸ τῶν ταπεινῶν δοξάζεται.
²¹ χαλεπώτερά σου μὴ ζητεῖ
καὶ ἰσχυρότερά σου μὴ ἐξέταξε.
²² ἂ προσετάγη σοι, ταῦτα διανοοῦ,
οὐ γάρ ἐστὶν σοι χρεία τῶν κρυπτῶν.
²³ ἐν τοῖς περισσοῖς τῶν ἔργων σου μὴ περιεργάζου.
πλείονα γὰρ συνέσεως ἀνθρώπων ὑπεδείχθη σοι.
²⁴ πολλοὺς γὰρ ἐπλάνησεν ἡ ὑπόληψις αὐτῶν,
καὶ ὑπόνοια πονηρὰ ὠλίσθησεν διανοίας αὐτῶν.

**כה באין אישון יחסר אור
ובאין דעת תחסר חכמה:**

¹⁸ The greater you are, humble yourself more,
and then you will find favour with the Lord.
¹⁹ *Many are the arrogant and renowned;
but, to the humble, he reveals his secrets.*
²⁰ For, great though the power of the Lord is,
he accepts the homage of the humble.
²¹ Don't seek things that are too hard for you,
or try to discover what is beyond your strength.
²² Concentrate on what has been assigned you;
you have no need to worry over mysteries.
²³ Do not meddle with matters that are beyond you,
for more than you can understand has been shown you.
²⁴ For, their own notions have misled many,
wicked presumption having warped their judgement.
²⁵ *When the eye has no pupil, there is no light;
and, without wisdom, there is no knowledge.*

¹⁸ The NJB ends the 1st line, "the more humbly you should behave."

¹⁹ This verse, present in the NRSV, WEBBE & NJB only as a footnote, is not part of the 'canonical' Greek text and neither is it present in *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'*; it is, however, present in the *Peshitta* and in the *Greek 248 MS*.

²⁰ The emphasis here (where the text follows the LXX) is on God's condescension in putting himself within the reach of the humblest. However, the *Genizah MS 'A'* reads, "For great is the mercy of God; he reveals his secrets to the humble," expresses an idea much more frequent in the Old Testament: God showers his favours on those who behave with humility (Ps 25:14, Pr 3:34, cf. Mt 11:25, Lk 1:52).

²¹ Vv. 21-24 preach against curiosity: the Law is a sufficient study for the wise. Perhaps, Ben Sira is preaching against Greek learning.

²² For the 1st line, *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'* reads, 'Think on what you are permitted' (במה שהורשית התבונן).

²³ 'Matters that are beyond you' *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'*; the LXX has 'your unnecessary works'.

²⁴ The 1st line here follows the LXX; *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'* has 'for, many are the conceits of the sons of men' (כי רבים עשתוני בני אדם).

²⁵ This verse, loosely following the NRSV/WEBBE (and *Greek 248 MS*), is in the NJB only as a footnote; in *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'*, it follows v. 27.

²⁶ καρδιά σκληρὰ κακωθήσεται ἐπ' ἐσχάτων,
καὶ ὁ ἀγαπῶν κίνδυνον ἐν αὐτῷ ἀπολεῖται.
²⁷ καρδιά σκληρὰ βαρυνθήσεται πόνοις,
καὶ ὁ ἁμαρτωλὸς προσθήσει ἁμαρτίαν ἐφ' ἁμαρτίαις.
²⁸ ἐπαγωγῇ ὑπερηφάνου οὐκ ἔστιν ἴασις·
φυτὸν γὰρ πονηρίας ἐρρίζωκεν ἐν αὐτῷ.
²⁹ καρδιά συνετοῦ διανοηθήσεται παραβολήν,
καὶ οὗς ἀκροατοῦ ἐπιθυμία σοφοῦ.
³⁰ πῦρ φλογιζόμενον ἀποσβέσει ὕδωρ,
καὶ ἐλεημοσύνη ἐξιλάσεται ἁμαρτίας.
³¹ ὁ ἀνταποδιδούς χάριτας μέμνηται εἰς τὰ μετὰ ταῦτα
καὶ ἐν καιρῷ πτώσεως αὐτοῦ εὕρησει στήριγμα.

²⁶ A stubborn heart will come to a bad end,
and whoever dallies with danger will perish in it.
²⁷ A stubborn heart is weighed down with troubles;
and the sinner heaps sin on sin.
²⁸ For the disease of the proud there is no cure,
since an evil weed has taken root in him.
²⁹ The heart of the sensible will reflect on proverbs;
an attentive ear is the sage's dream.
³⁰ As water puts out a blazing fire,
so almsgiving atones for sin.
³¹ He who gives favours in return is mindful of the future;
at the time of his falling, he will find support.

²⁶ The 2nd line here follows the LXX; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has, 'and he who loves good things will be led by them' (וְאוֹהֵב טוֹבוֹת יִנְהֵג בָהֶם).

²⁷ Abegg translates the 2nd line (Cairo Genizah MS 'A' – וּמִתְחַלֵּל מוֹסִיף עוֹן עַל עוֹן) as, "and the one who heaps sin upon sin is a raving lunatic."

²⁸ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (אֵל תִּרְוֹץ לְרַפְּאוֹת מַכַּת לֶץ כִּי אֵין לֵה רְפוּאָה כִּי מִנְטַע כִּי רַע נִטְעוּ) reads, "Do not hasten to heal the wound of a scoffer. For, there is no healing it; for, he is a plant of evil planting."

²⁹ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (לֵב חָכָם יִבִּין מִשְׁלֵי חֲכָמִים וְאָזֶן מִקְשֶׁבֶת לְחֲכָמָה תִּשְׁמַח) reads, "A wise heart will understand the proverbs of the wise; and the ear that listens to wisdom shall rejoice."

³⁰ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'justice' (צִדְקָה) in place of 'almsgiving'.

³¹ The text of the 1st line does not make it clear whether it means returning good for good or good for evil.

Σοφία Σιραχ 4

- ¹ Τέκνον, τὴν ζωὴν τοῦ πτωχοῦ μὴ ἀποστερήσης
καὶ μὴ παρελκύσης ὀφθαλμοὺς ἐπίδεξις.
- ² ψυχὴν πεινῶσαν μὴ λυπήσης
καὶ μὴ παροργίσῃς ἄνδρα ἐν ἀπορίᾳ αὐτοῦ.
- ³ καρδίαν παρωργισμένην μὴ προσταράξῃς
καὶ μὴ παρελκύσης δόσιν προσδεομένου.
- ⁴ ἰκέτην θλιβόμενον μὴ ἀπαναίνου
καὶ μὴ ἀποστρέψῃς τὸ πρόσωπόν σου ἀπὸ πτωχοῦ.
- ⁵ ἀπὸ δεομένου μὴ ἀποστρέψῃς ὀφθαλμόν
καὶ μὴ δῶς τόπον ἀνθρώπῳ καταράσασθαι σε·
- ⁶ καταρωμένου γάρ σε ἐν πικρίᾳ ψυχῆς αὐτοῦ
τῆς δεήσεως αὐτοῦ ἐπακούσεται ὁ ποιήσας αὐτόν.
- ⁷ προσφιλεῖ συναγωγῇ σεαυτὸν ποίει
καὶ μεγιστᾶνι ταπεινὸν τὴν κεφαλὴν σου.
- ⁸ κλιῖνον πτωχῷ τὸ οὖς σου
καὶ ἀποκριθήτι αὐτῷ εἰρηνικὰ ἐν πραύτητι.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 4

- ¹ My child, do not refuse the poor a livelihood;
do not tantalise the needy.
- ² Do not add to the sufferings of the hungry;
do not bait anyone in distress.
- ³ Do not aggravate a heart already angry,
nor keep the destitute waiting for your alms.
- ⁴ Do not reject a hard-pressed beggar,
nor turn your face from the poor.
- ⁵ Do not avert your eyes from the needy;
give no one occasion to curse you.
- ⁶ For if, in distress, someone curses you,
his Maker will give ear to his prayer.
- ⁷ Gain the love of the community;
in the presence of the great, bow your head.
- ⁸ To the poor, lend an ear,
and answer him with peaceful words in humility.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 4

- ¹ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' opens with '(My) Son' (בני) in place of 'My child', here following the LXX (Τέκνον).
- ² For this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (נפש חסירה אל תפוח ואל תתעלם ממדכדך נפש) reads, "Do not speak harshly to he who is hungry and do not hide from one he who is oppressed." (Note the pointing on the word, מִמְּדַכְּךָ, which doesn't occur elsewhere in this section of the MS.)
- ³ In Cairo Genizah MS 'A', there is a large stain where the word for 'aggravate' (תַּחְמִיר) is written, making it effectively illegible.
- ⁴ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads 'nor despise the requests of the needy' (ולא תבזה שאולות דל).
- ⁵ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' appears to omit the 1st line of this verse, reading just 'lest you give him cause to curse you' (ולא תתן לו מקום לקללך).
- ⁶ In place of 'his Maker', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'his Rock' (צור).
- ⁷ Another reading for 'community' is 'congregation'.
- ⁸ For the 2nd line, the NJB (possibly following Cairo Genizah MS 'A' - והשיבהו שלום בענוה) has 'and courteously return the greeting'.

⁹ ἐξελοῦ ἀδικούμενον ἐκ χειρὸς ἀδικοῦντος
καὶ μὴ ὀλιγοψυχήσης ἐν τῷ κρίνειν σε.
¹⁰ γίνου ὀρφανοῖς ὡς πατὴρ
καὶ ἀντὶ ἀνδρὸς τῇ μητρὶ αὐτῶν·
καὶ ἔσῃ ὡς υἱὸς ὑψίστου,
καὶ ἀγαπήσει σε μᾶλλον ἢ μήτηρ σου.
¹¹ Ἡ σοφία υἱοὺς αὐτῆς ἀνύψωσεν
καὶ ἐπιλαμβάνεται τῶν ζητοῦντων αὐτήν.
¹² ὁ ἀγαπῶν αὐτήν ἀγαπᾷ ζωὴν,
καὶ οἱ ὀρῶντες πρὸς αὐτήν
ἐμπλησθήσονται εὐφροσύνης.
¹³ ὁ κρατῶν αὐτῆς κληρονομήσει δόξαν,
καὶ οὗ εἰσπορεύεται, εὐλογεῖ κύριος.
¹⁴ οἱ λατρεύοντες αὐτῇ λειτουργήσουσιν ἀγίῳ,
καὶ τοὺς ἀγαπῶντας αὐτήν ἀγαπᾷ ὁ κύριος.
¹⁵ ὁ ὑπακούων αὐτῆς κρινεῖ ἔθνη,
καὶ ὁ προσέχων αὐτῇ κατασκηνώσει πεποιθώς.

⁹ Save the oppressed from the hand of the oppressor,
and do not be short-tempered in your judgements.
¹⁰ Be like a father to the fatherless
and as good as a husband to their mothers.
You will then be like a son to the Most High,
who will love you more than your own mother does.
¹¹ Wisdom teaches her own children
and cares for those who seek her.
¹² Whoever loves her loves life;
those who seek her early
will be filled with joy.
¹³ Whoever possesses her will inherit honour,
and wherever he enters, the Lord will bless.
¹⁴ Those who serve her minister to the Holy One,
and the Lord loves those who love her.
¹⁵ Whoever obeys her rules the nations;
whoever pays attention to her dwells secure.

⁹ For 'short-tempered', the NJB has 'mean-spirited' and the WEBBE has 'hesitant'.

¹⁰ In place of 'mothers' (in the 2nd line), here following the LXX, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'widows' (לאלמנות) and has the word on a line of its own, at the left-hand end of the line. This may be more acceptable: widows and orphans being typical of those to whom charity is enjoined (see Dt 10:18, 14:29, 24:19, et cetera, Ps 68:5, 146:9, Ezk 22:7).

¹¹ The NJB has 'brings up' in place of 'teaches', here following Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (למדה) and the Peshitta (and the NRSV); the LXX has 'exalts'. In vv. 11–19, Wisdom is personified (cf. Pr 1:23–25, 8:12–21, 9:1–6); her children are those who pursue wisdom and put it into practice (Lk 7:35).

¹² For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads 'And those who seek her shall obtain favour from Yahweh' (ומבקשיה יפיקו רצון מיה); the 3 yod characters in a triangular arrangement represent the Divine Name in this manuscript (and in some others from the Cairo Genizah).

¹³ Another reading for 'he enters' is 'she enters' (referring to Wisdom).

¹⁴ Service of wisdom is service of God, and God will love those who love her (Pr 8:17).

¹⁵ In Cairo Genizah MS 'A', vv. 15–19, in the first-person singular, are presented as a 'discourse of Wisdom', in imitation of Pr 1:22ff, 8:1ff.

¹⁶ ἔὰν ἐμπιστεύσῃ, κατακληρονομήσει αὐτήν,
καὶ ἐν κατασχέσει ἔσονται αἱ γενεαὶ αὐτοῦ.
¹⁷ ὅτι διεστραμμένως πορεύσεται μετ' αὐτοῦ ἐν πρώτοις,
φόβον καὶ δειλίαν ἐπάξει ἐπ' αὐτὸν
καὶ βασανίσει αὐτὸν ἐν παιδείᾳ αὐτῆς,
ἕως οὗ ἐμπιστεύσῃ τῇ ψυχῇ αὐτοῦ,
καὶ πειράσει αὐτὸν ἐν τοῖς δικαιώμασιν αὐτῆς.
¹⁸ καὶ πάλιν ἐπανήξει κατ' εὐθεῖαν πρὸς αὐτὸν
καὶ εὐφρανεῖ αὐτὸν
καὶ ἀποκαλύψει αὐτῷ τὰ κρυπτὰ αὐτῆς.
¹⁹ ἔὰν ἀποπλανηθῇ, ἐγκαταλείψει αὐτὸν
καὶ παραδώσει αὐτὸν εἰς χεῖρας πτώσεως αὐτοῦ.
²⁰ Συντήρησον καιρὸν καὶ φύλαξαι ἀπὸ πονηροῦ
καὶ περὶ τῆς ψυχῆς σου μὴ αἰσχυνθῆς.
²¹ ἔστιν γὰρ αἰσχύνῃ ἐπάγουσα ἀμαρτίαν,
καὶ ἔστιν αἰσχύνῃ δόξα καὶ χάρις.
²² μὴ λάβῃς πρόσωπον κατὰ τῆς ψυχῆς σου
καὶ μὴ ἐντραπῆς εἰς πτώσιν σου.

¹⁶ If he trusts himself to her, he will inherit her,
and his descendants will remain in possession of her.
¹⁷ For, at first, she will take him through winding ways;
bringing fear and faintness on him,
testing him with her discipline,
until she can trust him,
and she will test him with her ordeals.
¹⁸ Then she will come back to him on the straight road,
and making him happy
and revealing her secrets to him.
¹⁹ If he goes astray, however, she will abandon him
and leave him to his own destruction.
²⁰ Take circumstances into account and beware of evil,
and have no cause to be ashamed of yourself.
²¹ For, there is a shame that leads to sin
and a shame that is honourable and gracious.
²² Do not show partiality, discrediting your soul;
and do not revere any man to your falling.

¹⁶ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks this verse and this section is not extant in any other Hebrew witness.

¹⁷ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' opens 'For, I will go with him, making myself strange' (כי בהתנכר אלך עמו) (and cf. #15).

¹⁸ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'until his heart is filled with me'.

¹⁹ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'and hand him over to robbers' (ואסגירנו לשדדים).

²⁰ Vv. 20-31 probably allude to the temptation to which Jews were exposed under the impact of Hellenism, to dissimulate their faith and observances (see 1M 1:12-15, 2M 4:11-16).

²¹ In place of 'honourable and gracious', the NRSV has 'glory and favour'.

²² For this verse, here following the WEBBE, the NJB has, "Do not be too severe on yourself; do not let shame lead you to ruin." Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' and 'C' read 'Do not respect your own person and do not stumble at your own shortcomings' (אל תשא פניך על נפשך ואל תכשל למכשוליד); note that

²³ μὴ κωλύσης λόγον ἐν καιρῷ χρείας·
·תקנתך לא תכחש·

²⁴ ἐν γὰρ λόγῳ γνωσθήσεται σοφία
καὶ παιδεία ἐν ῥήματι γλώσσης.

²⁵ μὴ ἀντίλεγε τῇ ἀληθείᾳ
καὶ περὶ τῆς ἀπαιδευσίας σου ἐντρέπηθι.

²⁶ μὴ αἰσχυνῇς ὁμολογήσαι ἐφ' ἁμαρτίαις σου
καὶ μὴ βιάζου ῥοῦν ποταμοῦ.

²⁷ καὶ μὴ ὑποστρώσης ἀνθρώπῳ μωρῷ σεαυτὸν
καὶ μὴ λάβῃς πρόσωπον δυνάστου.

²⁸ ἕως θανάτου ἀγωνίσαι περὶ τῆς ἀληθείας,
καὶ κύριος ὁ θεὸς πολεμήσει ὑπὲρ σου.

²⁹ μὴ γίνου θρασὺς ἐν γλώσσῃ σου
καὶ νωθρὸς καὶ παρειμένος ἐν τοῖς ἔργοις σου.

³⁰ μὴ ἴσθι ὡς λέων ἐν τῷ οἴκῳ σου
καὶ φαντασιοκοπῶν ἐν τοῖς οἰκέταις σου.

²³ Do not refrain from speaking at the proper moment,
and do not hide your wisdom.

²⁴ For, your wisdom is made known by what you say,
your erudition by the word of the tongue.

²⁵ Do not contradict the truth;
rather be shamed for your own ignorance.

²⁶ Do not be ashamed to confess your sins;
do not try to stop the current of the river.

²⁷ Do not grovel to the foolish;
do not show partiality to the mighty.

²⁸ Fight to the death for truth,
and the Lord God will fight on your side.

²⁹ Do not be hasty with your tongue
and slack and negligent in your deeds.

³⁰ Do not be like a lion at home
and cowardly towards your servants.

MS 'C' has למכשולך in place of לשולך and, immediately before this verse, inserts the text of 20:22-23.

²³ 'At the proper moment' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'C' (בעיתו); the LXX has 'at a time of salvation' and the NJB has 'when it will do good'. The LXX lacks the 2nd line (here following Cairo Genizah MS 'C' and Greek 248).

²⁴ In place of 'the word of the tongue', the NJB has 'the word you utter'.

²⁵ The NJB has 'blush' in place of 'be shamed', here following the WEBBE.

²⁶ It is as futile to hide one's sins from God as to try to stop a river from flowing. The confession of sins was not unknown in Judaism (Lv 5:5, Nb 5:7, 2S 12:13, 1K 21:37, Ps 38:1,4-5, 51:5).

²⁷ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'and do not refute rulers to their face' (וואל תמאן לפני מושלים).

²⁸ Before this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' inserts the text of 8:14.

²⁹ For this verse, here loosely following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, "Do not be bold of tongue, yet idle and slack in deed."

³⁰ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'dog' (ככלב) in place of 'lion' (λέων), which makes the two lines synonymous rather than antithetical.

³¹ μὴ ἔστω ἡ χεὶρ σου ἐκτεταμένη εἰς τὸ λαβεῖν
καὶ ἐν τῷ ἀποδιδόναι συνεσταλμένη.

³¹ Do not let your hands be outstretched to receive,
yet clenched when the time comes to give back.

³¹ The NJB has 'tight-fisted' in place of 'clenched'.

Σοφία Σιραχ 5

- ¹ Μὴ ἔπεχε ἐπὶ τοῖς χρήμασίν σου
καὶ μὴ εἴπῃς Αὐτάρκη μοί ἐστιν.
² μὴ ἐξακολούθῃς τῇ ψυχῇ σου καὶ τῇ ἰσχύϊ σου
πορεύεσθαι ἐν ἐπιθυμίαις καρδίας σου·
³ καὶ μὴ εἴπῃς Τίς με δυναστεύσει;
ὁ γὰρ κύριος ἐκδικῶν ἐκδικήσῃ.
⁴ μὴ εἴπῃς Ἥμαρτον, καὶ τί μοι ἐγένετο;
ὁ γὰρ κύριός ἐστιν μακρόθυμος.
⁵ περὶ ἐξιλασμοῦ μὴ ἄφοβος γίνου
προσδεῖναι ἁμαρτίαν ἐφ' ἁμαρτίαις·
⁶ καὶ μὴ εἴπῃς Ὁ οἰκτιρμὸς αὐτοῦ πολὺς,
τὸ πλῆθος τῶν ἁμαρτιῶν μου ἐξιλάσεται·
ἔλεος γὰρ καὶ ὀργὴ παρ' αὐτῷ,
καὶ ἐπὶ ἁμαρτωλοὺς καταπαύσει ὁ θυμὸς αὐτοῦ.
⁷ μὴ ἀνάμενε ἐπιστρέψαι πρὸς κύριον
καὶ μὴ ὑπερβάλλου ἡμέραν ἐξ ἡμέρας·

WISDOM OF SIRACH 5

- ¹ Do not put your confidence in your money
or say, "With this, I am self-sufficient."
² Do not be led by your appetites and energy
to follow the passions of your heart.
³ Do not say, "Who has authority over me?"
For, the Lord will certainly give you your deserts.
⁴ Do not say, "I sinned, and what happened to me?"
For, the Lord is slow to anger.
⁵ Do not be so sure of forgiveness
that you add sin to sin.
⁶ Do not say, "His compassion is great,
he will forgive me my many sins."
For, both mercy and anger are with him,
and his indignation will rest on sinners.
⁷ Do not delay your return to the Lord;
do not put it off day after day;

WISDOM OF SIRACH 5

- ¹ Vv. 1-7 form a poem against presumption.
² For this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (אל תלך אחרי לבך ועיניך ללכת בחמודות רעה) reads, "Do not follow your heart and your eyes, to walk in evil desires."
³ This verse speaks of the 'fool' who, even if he does not deny the existence of God, at least denies his providence (Ps 53:1).
⁴ The sceptic defies divine justice when it is apparently inactive.
⁵ 'Forgiveness' follows Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' (סליחה); the LXX has 'atonement' (ἐξιλασμοῦ). The added sin of the 2nd line is presumption.
⁶ The NJB has 'retribution' in place of 'anger' and 'anger' in place of 'indignation'.
⁷ Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' have 'to him' in place of 'to the Lord'.

ἐξάπινα γὰρ ἐξελεύσεται ὀργὴ κυρίου,
καὶ ἐν καιρῷ ἐκδικήσεως ἐξολῇ.
8 Μὴ ἔπεχε ἐπὶ χρήμασιν ἀδίκους·
οὐδὲν γὰρ ὠφελήσῃ σε ἐν ἡμέρᾳ ἐπαγωγῆς.
9 μὴ λίκμα ἐν παντὶ ἀνέμῳ
καὶ μὴ πορεύου ἐν πάσῃ ἀτραπῷ·
οὕτως ὁ ἁμαρτωλὸς ὁ δίγλωσσος.
10 ἴσθι ἐστηριγμένος ἐν συνέσει σου,
καὶ εἷς ἔστω σου ὁ λόγος.
11 Γίνου ταχὺς ἐν ἀκροάσει σου
καὶ ἐν μακροθυμίᾳ φθέγγου ἀποκρισιν.
12 εἰ ἔστιν σοι σύνεσις, ἀποκρίθητι τῷ πλησίον·
εἰ δὲ μή, ἡ χεὶρ σου ἔστω ἐπὶ τῷ στόματί σου.
13 δόξα καὶ ἀτιμία ἐν λαλιᾷ,
καὶ γλῶσσα ἀνθρώπου πτώσις αὐτῷ.
14 Μὴ κληθῇς ψίδυρος
καὶ τῇ γλώσσῃ σου μὴ ἐνέδρευε
ἐπὶ γὰρ τῷ κλέπτῃ ἐστὶν αἰσχύνη
καὶ κατὰγνωσις πονηρὰ ἐπὶ διγλώσσου.

For, suddenly the Lord's wrath will blaze out
and, on the day of punishment, you will perish.
8 Do not set your heart on dishonest wealth;
for, it will not benefit you on the day of disaster.
9 Do not winnow in every wind,
or walk along by every by-way,
as the double-talking sinner does.
10 Be steady in your convictions,
and be a person of your word.
11 Be quick to listen
and patient when giving an answer.
12 If you understand a matter, answer your neighbour;
if not, keep your hand over your mouth.
13 Both honour and disgrace come from talking;
the tongue is its owner's downfall.
14 Do not be called a double-dealer;
do not set traps with your tongue.
For, as shame lies in store for the thief,
so harsh condemnation awaits the deceitful.

8 Cairo Genizah MS 'C' omits this verse, though it is included in MS 'A' (אל תבטח על נכסי שקר כי לא יועילו ביום עברה).

9 The NJB parenthesises the 3rd line, here following the LXX, and the NRSV includes it only as a footnote; it is not present the Cairo Genizah MSS.

10 For this verse, Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' read, 'Be sure of your knowledge and then speak' (היה סמוך על דברך ואחר יהיה דברך).

11 For 'patient', Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' have 'slow of spirit'.

12 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (אם יש אתך ענה רעך ואם אין ידך על פיך) and MS 'C' (אם יש אתך ענה ריעיד ואם אין שים ידך על פיך) have slightly different texts for this verse.

13 Ben Sira takes up the topic of the tongue (use and abuse) frequently: 19:6–17, 20:16–20, 22:7–23:15, 28:12–26.

14 'Double-dealer' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (בשל שתיים); the LXX has 'slanderer' (ψίδυρος).

15 ἐν μεγάλῳ καὶ ἐν μικρῷ μὴ ἀγνόει
καὶ ἀντὶ φίλου μὴ γίνου ἐχθρός·

15 Do not act corruptly in great or small matters,
and do not exchange friendship for enmity.

15 'Do not act corruptly' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (אל תשחת) and the Peshitta; the LXX has 'do not be ignorant'. The NRSV includes the 2nd line in 6:1.

Σοφία Σιραχ 6

- ¹ ὄνομα γὰρ πονηρὸν αἰσχύνῃ καὶ ὄνειδος κληρονομῇ·
οὕτως ὁ ἁμαρτωλὸς ὁ δίγλωσσος.
- ² Μὴ ἐπάρῃς σεαυτὸν ἐν βουλῇ ψυχῆς σου,
ἵνα μὴ διαρπαγῇ ὡς ταῦρος ἡ ψυχὴ σου·
- ³ τὰ φύλλα σου καταφάγῃ
καὶ τοὺς καρπούς σου ἀπολέσεις
καὶ ἀφήσεις σεαυτὸν ὡς ξύλον ξηρόν.
- ⁴ ψυχὴ πονηρὰ ἀπολεῖ τὸν κτησάμενον αὐτήν
καὶ ἐπίχαρμα ἐχθρῶν ποιήσῃ αὐτόν.
- ⁵ Λάρυγξ γλυκὺς πληθυνεῖ φίλους αὐτοῦ,
καὶ γλῶσσα εὐλαλὸς πληθυνεῖ εὐπροσῆγορα.
- ⁶ οἱ εἰρηνεύοντές σοι ἔστωσαν πολλοί,
οἱ δὲ σύμβουλοί σου εἷς ἀπὸ χιλίων.
- ⁷ εἰ κτᾶσαι φίλον, ἐν πειρασμῷ κτῆσαι αὐτόν
καὶ μὴ ταχὺ ἐμπιστεύσῃς αὐτῷ.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 6

- ¹ For, a bad name will earn you shame and reproach,
as happens to the double-talking sinner.
- ² Do not exalt yourself in the counsel of your soul,
for fear your strength tears itself apart like a bull.
- ³ You will devour your leaves
and your destroy fruit,
and you will be left like a withered tree.
- ⁴ An evil temper destroys the person who has it
and makes him the laughing stock of his enemies.
- ⁵ A kindly turn of speech attracts new friends;
a courteous tongue invites many a friendly response.
- ⁶ Let your acquaintances be many
but, for advisers, choose one out of a thousand.
- ⁷ If you want to make a friend, take him on trial,
and do not be in a hurry to trust him.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 6

- ¹ In the *Rahlfs-Hanhart* text, this verse is included as part of 5:15; and, in that text, this chapter begins at v. 2.
- ² For the 1st line, the *NJB* has ‘Do not get carried aloft on the wings of passion’, claiming to follow the ‘Hebrew text’; however, *Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’* (which is the only extant Hebrew text for this verse) reads much the same as the translation presented here (אל תפול ביד נפשך), which follows that of the *WEBBE*. The *NRSV* has ‘Do not fall into the grip of passion’.
- ³ For ‘destroy’, here following the *LXX* (ἀπολέσεις), *Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’* reads ‘uproot’ (תשרש).
- ⁴ In place of ‘evil temper’, here following the *NJB*, the *WEBBE* has ‘wicked soul’.
- ⁵ Vv. 5–17 discuss true and false friendship – a frequent topic (see 11:29–12:18, 22:19–26, 37:1–6).
- ⁶ The literal translation of ‘acquaintances’ is ‘those who are at peace with you’, or possibly, ‘those who wish peace to you’.
- ⁷ Friends are to be tested, lest they turn out to be ‘fair-weather friends’ (vv. 5 –12); true friends are a treasure, a gift from God (vv. 13–17).

8 ἔστιν γὰρ φίλος ἐν καιρῷ αὐτοῦ
καὶ οὐ μὴ παραμείνῃ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ θλίψεώς σου.
9 καὶ ἔστιν φίλος μετατιθέμενος εἰς ἔχθραν
καὶ μάχην ὀνειδισμοῦ σου ἀποκαλύψει.
10 καὶ ἔστιν φίλος κοινωνὸς τραπεζῶν
καὶ οὐ μὴ παραμείνῃ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ θλίψεώς σου.
11 καὶ ἐν τοῖς ἀγαθοῖς σου ἔσται ὡς σὺ
καὶ ἐπὶ τοὺς οἰκέτας σου παρρησιάζεται.
12 ἐὰν ταπεινωθῇς, ἔσται κατὰ σοῦ
καὶ ἀπὸ τοῦ προσώπου σου κρυβήσεται.
13 ἀπὸ τῶν ἐχθρῶν σου διαχωρίσθητι
καὶ ἀπὸ τῶν φίλων σου πρόσσεχε.
14 φίλος πιστὸς σκέπη κραταιά,
ὁ δὲ εὐρὼν αὐτὸν εὗρεν θησαυρόν.
15 φίλου πιστοῦ οὐκ ἔστιν ἀντάλλαγμα,
καὶ οὐκ ἔστιν σταθμὸς τῆς καλλονῆς αὐτοῦ.
16 φίλος πιστὸς φάρμακον ζωῆς,
καὶ οἱ φοβούμενοι κύριον εὐρήσουσιν αὐτόν.

8 For, one kind of friend is so only on occasions
but will not stand by you in your day of trouble.
9 Another kind of friend will fall out with you
and, will expose the quarrel, to your shame.
10 A third kind of friend will sit at your table
but will not remain in your day of trouble.
11 When you are doing well, he will be your second self,
and he will order your servants about;
12 but, if disaster befalls you, he will recoil from you
and will hide himself from your face.
13 Keep well clear of your enemies
and be wary of your friends.
14 A faithful friend is a powerful defence:
whoever finds one has found a treasure.
15 A faithful friend is something beyond price
and there is no measuring his value.
16 A faithful friend is the elixir of life,
and those who fear the Lord will find one.

8 In place of 'on occasions', the NJB has 'when it suits him'. Cairo Genizah MS 'C' omits this verse.

9 In place of 'exposes', here following the LXX (ἀποκαλύψει) and Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (יחשוך), Cairo Genizah MS 'C' has 'withholds' (יחשוך).

10 For 'but (and) will not remain', here following the LXX (καὶ οὐ μὴ παραμείνῃ), Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' have 'but not be found' (ולא ימצא).

11 For the 2nd line, here following the LXX, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'and in your adversity he will turn away' (וברעתך יתנדה ממך).

12 For the 2nd line, the NJB has, "and keep out of your way."

13 Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' have near identical text for this verse (which is generally concordant with that of the LXX); the one difference is that MS 'A' (מאהביך) lacks the conjunction at the start of the 2nd line but MS 'C' (ומאהביך) includes it.

14 The NJB has 'loyal' in place of 'faithful', here following the WEBBE (as also in vv. 15 & 16).

15 The WEBBE has 'excellency' in place of 'value'.

16 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'God' in place of 'the Lord' and MS 'C' omits this verse (and v. 7).

¹⁷ ὁ φοβούμενος κύριον εὐθυνεῖ φιλίαν αὐτοῦ,
 ὅτι κατ' αὐτὸν οὕτως καὶ ὁ πλησίον αὐτοῦ.
¹⁸ Τέκνον, ἐκ νεότητός σου ἐπίλεξαι παιδείαν,
 καὶ ἕως πολιῶν εὐρήσεις σοφίαν.
¹⁹ ὥς ὁ ἀροτριῶν καὶ ὁ σπείρων πρόσελθε αὐτῇ
 καὶ ἀνάμενε τοὺς ἀγαθοὺς καρποὺς αὐτῆς·
 ἐν γὰρ τῇ ἐργασίᾳ αὐτῆς ὀλίγον κοπιάσεις
 καὶ ταχὺ φάγεσαι τῶν γενημάτων αὐτῆς.
²⁰ ὥς τραχεῖά ἐστιν σφόδρα τοῖς ἀπαιδεύτοις,
 καὶ οὐκ ἐμμενεῖ ἐν αὐτῇ ἀκάρδιος·
²¹ ὥς λίθος δοκιμασίας ἰσχυρὸς ἔσται ἐπ' αὐτῷ,
 καὶ οὐ χρονιεῖ ἀπορριῖψαι αὐτήν.
²² σοφία γὰρ κατὰ τὸ ὄνομα αὐτῆς ἐστιν
 καὶ οὐ πολλοῖς ἐστιν φανερά.
²³ Ἄκουσον, τέκνον, καὶ ἐκδεξαι γνώμην μου
 καὶ μὴ ἀπαναίνου τὴν συμβουλίαν μου·
²⁴ καὶ εἰσένεγκον τοὺς πόδας σου εἰς τὰς πέδας αὐτῆς
 καὶ εἰς τὸν κλοιὸν αὐτῆς τὸν τράχηλόν σου·

¹⁷ Whoever fears the Lord makes true friends,
 for, as a person is, so is his friend too.
¹⁸ My child, from your earliest youth, choose instruction,
 and, until your hair is white, you will find wisdom.
¹⁹ Like one who ploughs and sows, approach her
 and wait for her fine harvest;
 for, in tilling her, you will toil a little while,
 but, very soon, you will be eating her crops.
²⁰ How very harsh she is to the fool!
 The senseless does not stay with her for long.
²¹ She will rest on the senseless like a heavy stone
 and such a person will lose no time in throwing her off.
²² For, Wisdom is true to her name
 and she is not accessible to many.
²³ Listen, my child, and take my advice,
 do not reject my counsel.
²⁴ Put your feet into her fetters
 and your neck into her collar.

-
- ¹⁷ The 2nd line is usually read, 'for his friend is as dear to him as himself' but equally probable is 'for his friend will be inevitably like himself', god-fearing. True piety is the guarantee of friendship.
¹⁸ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks this verse but it is included in MS 'C'.
¹⁹ The NJB has 'cultivate' in place of 'approach' but this is not supported by either the LXX or Cairo Genizah MSS.
²⁰ In place of 'fool', the NJB has 'undisciplined' and the WEBBE has 'unlearned'.
²¹ For the 1st line, the NJB reads, "She will weigh as heavily on the senseless as a touchstone."
²² The Cairo Genizah MS 'A' text for this verse (כִּי הַמוֹסֵר כַּמְשָׁה כֵּן הוּא וְלֹא לְרַבִּים הִיא נְכוּחָה) is not easy to translated precisely; Abegg has, "For, she and discipline are one and the same, and not many are willing to accept her as the right way of life."
²³ For this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has the text of 27:5.
²⁴ For this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has the text of 27:6.

²⁵ ὑπόθες τὸν ὤμόν σου καὶ βάσταξον αὐτήν
καὶ μὴ προσοχθίσῃς τοῖς δεσμοῖς αὐτῆς.
²⁶ ἐν πάσῃ ψυχῇ σου πρόσσελθε αὐτῇ
καὶ ἐν ὅλῃ δυνάμει σου συντήρησον τὰς ὁδοὺς αὐτῆς.
²⁷ ἐξίχνευσον καὶ ζήτησον, καὶ γνωσθήσεται σοι,
καὶ ἐγκρατὴς γενόμενος μὴ ἀφῇς αὐτήν.
²⁸ ἐπ' ἐσχάτων γὰρ εὐρήσεις τὴν ἀνάπαυσιν αὐτῆς,
καὶ στραφήσεται σοι εἰς εὐφροσύνην.
²⁹ καὶ ἔσονται σοι αἱ πέδαι εἰς σκέπην ἰσχύος
καὶ οἱ κλοιοὶ αὐτῆς εἰς στολὴν δόξης.
³⁰ κόσμος γὰρ χρύσεός ἐστιν ἐπ' αὐτῆς,
καὶ οἱ δεσμοὶ αὐτῆς κλῶσμα ὑακίνθινον.
³¹ στολὴν δόξης ἐνδύσῃ αὐτήν
καὶ στέφανον ἀγαλλιάματος περιθήσεις σεαυτῷ.
³² Ἐὰν θέλῃς, τέκνον, παιδευθήσῃ,
καὶ ἐὰν ἐπιθῶς τὴν ψυχὴν σου, πανοῦργος ἔσῃ.
³³ ἐὰν ἀγαπήσῃς ἀκούειν, ἐκδέξῃ,
καὶ ἐὰν κλίνῃς τὸ οὖς σου, σοφὸς ἔσῃ.

²⁵ Offer your shoulder to her burden;
do not be impatient of her bonds.
²⁶ Court her with all your soul
and, with all your might, keep in her ways.
²⁷ Search for her, track her down; she will reveal herself;
and, holding her fast, do not let her go.
²⁸ For, in the end, you will find rest in her
and she will be turned for you into joy.
²⁹ Her fetters you will find a mighty defence,
her locks a robe of glory.
³⁰ Her yoke will be a golden ornament,
and her bonds will be purple ribbons.
³¹ You will wear her like a robe of honour;
you will put her on like a crown of joy.
³² If you wish it, my child, you can be taught;
and, if you apply yourself, you will be prudent.
³³ If you love listening, you will learn;
and, if you pay attention, you will become wise.

²⁵ The meaning of 'her bonds' here is uncertain; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has **וואל תקץ בתחבולתיה**, which may refer to 'her cords' or 'her counsel'.

²⁶ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks this verse.

²⁷ The NJB opens the 2nd line, "once you hold her."

²⁸ For the 2nd line, here (loosely) following the WEBBE, the NJB has, "and she will take the form of joy for you."

²⁹ In place of 'robe of glory', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'golden garment' (**בגדי כהם**).

³⁰ 'Her yoke' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (**עלי**); the LXX has 'on her' – probably a misreading by the original translator; on the 'purple ribbons'.

³¹ The NRSV, following Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (**ועטרת תפארת תעטרנה**), has 'splendid crown' in place of 'crown of joy', here following the LXX (and NJB). The last part of this verse is the only substantial text of the book found in Qumran Scroll 2Q18 (2QSir), reading, **ת תפארת תעטרנה**[...].

³² The NJB has 'become intelligent' in place of 'be prudent'.

³³ The literal translation of 'pay attention' is 'incline your ear'.

³⁴ ἐν πλήθει πρεσβυτέρων στῆθι·
καὶ τίς σοφός; αὐτῷ προσκολληθήσῃτι.
³⁵ πᾶσαν διήγησιν θείαν θέλε ἀκροᾶσθαι,
καὶ παροιμίαι συνέσεως μὴ ἐκφευγέτωσάν σε.
³⁶ ἐὰν ἴδῃς συνετόν, ὄρῃριζε πρὸς αὐτόν,
καὶ βαθμοὺς θυρῶν αὐτοῦ ἐκτριβέτω ὁ πούς σου.
³⁷ διανοοῦ ἐν τοῖς προστάγμασιν κυρίου
καὶ ἐν ταῖς ἐντολαῖς αὐτοῦ μελέτα διὰ παντός·
αὐτὸς στηριεῖ τὴν καρδίαν σου,
καὶ ἡ ἐπιθυμία τῆς σοφίας δοθήσεται σοι.

³⁴ Attend the gathering of elders;
if there is a wise man there, attach yourself to him.
³⁵ Listen willingly to any divine discourse;
and do not let wise proverbs escape you.
³⁶ If you see a man of understanding, visit him early;
let your feet wear out his doorsteps.
³⁷ Reflect on the injunctions of the Lord;
busy yourself at all times with his commandments.
He will strengthen your mind
and the wisdom you desire will be granted you.

³⁴ One way of becoming wise is to seek out the intelligent and frequent their company (vv. 34–36). *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'* lacks this verse.

³⁵ In place of 'divine discourse', the NJB has 'discourse coming from God'; *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'* lacks the adjective,

³⁶ The NJB has the singular, 'doorstep'; a more literal translation is 'the steps of his doors'.

³⁷ Attaining wisdom means fidelity to the Law (see also 15:1, 19:20, 23:27, 24:33). In place of 'the Lord' (*κυρίου*), *Cairo Genizah MS 'A'* has 'the Most High (God)' (*יְיָ*).

Σοφία Σιραχ 7

- ¹ Μὴ ποίει κακά, καὶ οὐ μὴ σε καταλάβῃ κακόν·
² ἀπόστηθι ἀπὸ ἀδίκου, καὶ ἐκκλινεῖ ἀπὸ σοῦ.
³ υἱέ, μὴ σπεῖρε ἐπ’ αὐλακας ἀδικίας,
καὶ οὐ μὴ θερίσῃς αὐτὰ ἐπταπλασίως.
⁴ μὴ ζῇται παρὰ κυρίου ἡγεμονίαν
μηδὲ παρὰ βασιλέως καθεδρὰν δόξης.
⁵ μὴ δικαιοῦ ἔναντι κυρίου
καὶ παρὰ βασιλεῖ μὴ σοφίζου.
⁶ μὴ ζῇται γενέσθαι κριτῆς,
μὴ οὐκ ἰσχύσεις ἐξῆραι ἀδικίας,
μήποτε εὐλαβηθῇς ἀπὸ προσώπου δυνάστου
καὶ θῇσεις σκάνδαλον ἐν εὐδύτητί σου.
⁷ μὴ ἀμάρτανε εἰς πλῆθος πόλεως
καὶ μὴ καταβάλλῃς σεαυτὸν ἐν ὄχλῳ.
⁸ μὴ καταδεσμεύσῃς δις ἁμαρτίαν·
ἐν γὰρ τῇ μιᾷ οὐκ ἀθῶος ἔσῃ.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 7

- ¹ Do no evil and evil will not overtake you;
² depart from wrong and it will avoid you.
³ My son, do not sow in the furrows of wickedness,
for fear you have to reap them seven times over.
⁴ Do not ask the Lord for the highest place,
or the king for a seat of honour.
⁵ Do not justify yourself before the Lord,
or parade your wisdom before the king.
⁶ Do not scheme to be a judge,
for fear you should be unable to stamp out injustice,
for fear of being swayed by someone influential
and so of risk of losing your integrity.
⁷ Do not wrong the general body of citizens
and so lower yourself in popular esteem.
⁸ Do not commit a sin twice;
for, you will not go unpunished even once.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 7

- ¹ In place of ‘overtake’, here following the LXX and Cairo Genizah MSS ‘A’ & ‘C’, and the WEBBE, the NJB has ‘befall’.
² Cairo Genizah MSS ‘A’ & ‘C’ have ‘stay away’ in place of ‘depart’.
³ The NRSV, following the Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’, lacks ‘My son’, here following the LXX; Cairo Genizah MS ‘C’ omits this verse.
⁴ Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ has ‘dominion’ (ממשלת) in place of ‘the highest place’.
⁵ Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ has ‘king’ (מלך) in place of ‘the Lord’.
⁶ Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ has ‘ruler’ (מושל) in place of ‘judge’.
⁷ For this verse, Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ reads, “Do not condemn yourself in the congregation at the gates (?) and do not cast yourself down in the assembly.” (אל תרשיעך בעדת שערי אל אל תפילך בקהלה)
⁸ For the 1st line, here following the WEBBE, the NJB has, “Do not be drawn to sin twice over.”

9 μὴ εἴπῃς Τῷ πλήθει τῶν δώρων μου ἐπόψεται
καὶ ἐν τῷ προσενέγκαι με θεῷ ὑψίστῳ προσδέξεται.
10 μὴ ὀλιγοψυχήσῃς ἐν τῇ προσευχῇ σου
καὶ ἐλεημοσύνην ποιῆσαι μὴ παρίδῃς.
11 μὴ καταγέλα ἄνθρωπον ὄντα ἐν πικρίᾳ ψυχῆς αὐτοῦ·
ἔστιν γὰρ ὁ ταπεινῶν καὶ ἄνυσῶν.
12 μὴ ἀροτρία ψεῦδος ἐπ' ἀδελφῷ σου
μηδὲ φίλῳ τὸ ὅμοιον ποίει.
13 μὴ θέλῃς ψεύδῃσθαι πᾶν ψεῦδος·
ὁ γὰρ ἐνδελεχισμὸς αὐτοῦ οὐκ εἰς ἀγαθόν.
14 μὴ ἀδολέσχῃ ἐν πλήθει πρεσβυτέρων
καὶ μὴ δευτερώσῃς λόγον ἐν προσευχῇ σου.
15 μὴ μισήσῃς ἐπίπονον ἐργασίαν
καὶ γεωργίαν ὑπὸ ὑψίστου ἐκτισμένην.
16 μὴ προσλογίζου σεαυτὸν ἐν πλήθει ἁμαρτωλῶν·
μνήσθητι ὅτι ὀργὴ οὐ χρονιεῖ.

9 Do not say, "He will look on the multitude of my gifts;
when I sacrifice to God Most High, he will accept."
10 Do not be hesitant in prayer
and do not neglect to give alms.
11 Do not laugh at someone who is sad of heart,
for he who brings low can lift up high.
12 Do not devise lies against your brother,
nor against a friend either.
13 Mind you tell no lies,
for no good can come of it.
14 Do not babble at the gathering of elders
and do not repeat yourself at your prayers.
15 Do not shirk tiring jobs
or farm work, ordained by the Most High.
16 Do not swell the ranks of sinners;
remember that the retribution will not delay.

9 For this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has the text of v. 15.

10 The Cairo Genizah MS 'A' text for the 2nd line (ובצדקה אל תתעב) is uncertain and Abegg translates it as, "lest righteousness be neglected." Note that the Hebrew text ends with a (very) wide *resh*.

11 This role of God is emphasised also in 1S 2:8.

12 'Devise' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (תחרו); the LXX has 'plough' (ἀροτρία).

13 The literal translation of the 2nd line (here following the LXX and NJB) is 'its continuity is not good' (the NRSV has 'for it is a habit that results in no good'). The meaning is uncertain but confirmed by Cairo Genizah MS 'A': 'for, the result is not good' (כי תקותו לא תנעס).

14 In place of 'babble', here following the WEBBE, the NJB has 'talk too much'.

15 See #9. The (misplaced) text of Cairo Genizah MS 'A' is: אל תאיץ בצבא מלאכת עבדה הי כאל נחלקה ("Do not rush through a laborious task when you do your service; it has been apportioned to you by God.")

16 In the context of v. 15, this verse talks of considering oneself better than others.

¹⁷ ταπεινώσον σφόδρα τὴν ψυχὴν σου,
ὅτι ἐκδίκησις ἀσεβοῦς πῦρ καὶ σκώληξ.
¹⁸ Μὴ ἀλλάξης φίλον ἕνεκεν διαφόρου
μηδὲ ἀδελφὸν γνήσιον ἐν χρυσίῳ Σουφίρ.
¹⁹ μὴ ἀστόχει γυναικὸς σοφῆς καὶ ἀγαθῆς·
ἡ γὰρ χάρις αὐτῆς ὑπὲρ τὸ χρυσίον.
²⁰ μὴ κακώσης οἰκέτην ἐργαζόμενον ἐν ἀληθείᾳ
μηδὲ μίσθιον διδόντα τὴν ψυχὴν αὐτοῦ.
²¹ οἰκέτην συνετὸν ἀγαπάτω σου ἡ ψυχὴ,
μὴ στερήσης αὐτὸν ἐλευθερίας.
²² κτήνη σοὶ ἔστιν; ἐπισκέπτου αὐτά·
καὶ εἰ ἔστιν σοι χρήσιμα, ἐμμενέτω σοι.
²³ τέκνα σοὶ ἔστιν; παίδευσον αὐτὰ
καὶ κάμψον ἐκ νεότητος τὸν τράχηλον αὐτῶν.

¹⁷ Be very humble,
since the recompense for the godless is fire and worms.
¹⁸ Do not barter a friend away for the sake of profit,
nor a true brother for the gold of Ophir.
¹⁹ Do not dismiss a wise and good wife;
her gracious presence is worth more than gold.
²⁰ Do not ill-treat a slave who is an honest worker,
or a wage earner who is devoted to you.
²¹ Love an intelligent slave with all your heart,
and do not deny such a slave his freedom.
²² Do you have cattle? Look after them;
if they are making you a profit, keep them.
²³ Do you have children? Discipline them,
and make them obedient from their youth.

¹⁷ For the 2nd line, here following the LXX, Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' have *כי תקות אנוש [ל]רמה* ('for, the expectation of mortals is worms').

¹⁸ 'Ophir', on the coast of southern Arabia or eastern Africa, was famous for its gold (1K 9:28).

¹⁹ In place of 'dismiss', here following Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (and NRSV), the LXX has 'deprive yourself of'; the NJB has 'turn against'. An alternative reading for the 1st line is, "Do not hesitate to marry a wise and good wife;" (see v. 26).

²⁰ The 2 Cairo Genizah MSS differ slightly in this verse: MS 'A' has *עובד אמת וכן שוכר נותן נפשו* whereas MS 'C' opens instead with (albeit in poorly preserved text) *אל תר[.] עבד עובד*.

²¹ The literal translation of the 1st line (here following the LXX) is, "Let your soul love an intelligent slave." The translator seems to have misunderstood the Hebrew: *עבד משכיל חבב כנפש* ('Love as your soul an intelligent slave.');

²² Cairo Genizah MS 'C' omits this verse but MS 'A' has it – *בהמה לך ראה עיניך ואם אמנה היא העמידה*; the text very similar to that of the LXX.

²³ The NJB has 'educate' in place of 'discipline' and 'bow the neck' (LXX) in place of 'obedient' (Hebrew).

²⁴ θυγατέρες σοί εἰσιν; πρόσεχε τῷ σώματι αὐτῶν
καὶ μὴ ἱλαρώσης πρὸς αὐτὰς τὸ πρόσωπόν σου.
²⁵ ἔκδου θυγατέρα, καὶ ἔση τετελεκὼς ἔργον μέγα,
καὶ ἀνδρὶ συνετῷ δώρησαι αὐτήν.
²⁶ γυνή σοί ἐστίν κατὰ ψυχὴν;
μὴ ἐκβάλῃς αὐτήν·
καὶ μισουμένη μὴ ἐμπιστεύσῃς σεαυτόν.
²⁷ Ἐν ὅλῃ καρδίᾳ σου δόξασον τὸν πατέρα σου
καὶ μητρὸς ὠδῖνας μὴ ἐπιλάθῃ.
²⁸ μνήσθητι ὅτι δι' αὐτῶν ἐγεννήθης,
καὶ τί ἀνταποδώσεις αὐτοῖς καθὼς αὐτοὶ σοί;
²⁹ ἐν ὅλῃ ψυχῇ σου εὐλαβοῦ τὸν κύριον
καὶ τοὺς ἱερεῖς αὐτοῦ θαύμαζε.
³⁰ ἐν ὅλῃ δυνάμει ἀγάπησον τὸν ποιήσαντά σε
καὶ τοὺς λειτουργοὺς αὐτοῦ μὴ ἐγκαταλίπῃς.
³¹ φοβοῦ τὸν κύριον καὶ δόξασον ἱερέα
καὶ δὸς τὴν μερίδα αὐτῷ, καθὼς ἐντέταλταί σοι,

²⁴ Do you have daughters? Take care of their chastity
and don't be overly indulgent towards them.
²⁵ Marry a daughter off and you have done a great work;
but give her to a man of understanding.
²⁶ Do you have a wife who pleases you?
Don't turn her out;
but, if you do not love her, never trust her.
²⁷ With all your heart, honour your father;
never forget the birth pangs of your mother.
²⁸ Remember that you owe your birth to them;
how can you repay them for what they did for you?
²⁹ With all your soul, fear the Lord
and revere his priests.
³⁰ With all your might, love him who made you,
and do not abandon his ministers.
³¹ Fear the Lord and honour the priest
and give him the portion enjoined on you:

²⁴ The NJB, following the LXX, has 'bodies' for 'chastity', here following Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'C' (and NRSV). On daughters, see 42:9–14.

²⁵ At the end of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds 'a companion' (חברה).

²⁶ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' and the Peshitta lack 'who pleases you'. Many MSS omit the 2nd line.

²⁷ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks vv. 27–28.

²⁸ The NJB & WEBBE have 'have done' in place of 'did'.

²⁹ Ben Sira reveres the liturgy and its ministers (see Ch. 50). Here, reverence for the priest is juxtaposed with worship of the Lord in the same spirit as those texts to which v. 31 alludes: Ex 29:27, Lv 5:6 (sacrifices of reparation, or 'for sin'), 7:32, Nb 18:11–18 (first fruits), Dt 18:3 (the 'shoulder gift' of v. 31).

³⁰ A more literal reading of 'ministers' is 'servants'.

³¹ The 'sanctification sacrifice' (Hebrew 'of right behaviour') is probably the oblation of Lv 2:1–16.

ἀπαρχὴν καὶ περὶ πλημμελείας καὶ δόσιν βραχιόνων
καὶ θυσίαν ἁγιασμοῦ καὶ ἀπαρχὴν ἁγίων.

- ³² Καὶ πτωχῷ ἔκτεινον τὴν χεῖρά σου,
ἵνα τελειωθῇ ἡ εὐλογία σου.
- ³³ χάρις δόματος ἔναντι παντὸς ζῶντος,
καὶ ἐπὶ νεκρῷ μὴ ἀποκωλύσης χάριν.
- ³⁴ μὴ ὑστέρει ἀπὸ κλαιόντων
καὶ μετὰ πενθούντων πένθησον.
- ³⁵ μὴ ὀκνεῖ ἐπισκέπτεσθαι ἄρρωστον ἄνθρωπον·
ἐκ γὰρ τῶν τοιούτων ἀγαπηθήσῃ.
- ³⁶ ἐν πᾶσι τοῖς λόγοις σου μιμνήσκου τὰ ἔσχατά σου,
καὶ εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα οὐχ ἁμαρτήσεις.

First fruits, sacrifice of reparation, shoulder gift,
sanctification sacrifice, and first fruits of holy things.

- ³² Also, give generously to the poor,
so that your blessing may lack nothing.
- ³³ Let your generosity extend to all the living;
do not withhold it even from the dead.
- ³⁴ Do not turn your back on those who weep
and mourn with those who mourn.
- ³⁵ Do not be slow in visiting the sick;
in this way, you will make yourself loved.
- ³⁶ In everything you do, remember your end,
and you will never sin.

³² The 'blessing' is that given by God.

³³ On the duty of giving decent burial to the dead, see 2S 21:10–14, Tb 1:17–18, 12:12, Is 34:3, Jr 22:19. At a later period, prayers and sacrifices were also offered for them (2M 12:38–46). However, the Law seems to have forbidden certain non-Jewish rites connected with the dead (Dt 26:14, cf. Si 30:18, Ba 6:26). Ben Sira does not go into details.

³⁴ For the 2nd line, here following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, "but share the grief of the grief-stricken."

³⁵ For the 1st line, here following the LXX, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads **אל תשא לב מאוהב** ('Do not withdraw your heart from a friend').

³⁶ In place of 'do' (here following Cairo Genizah MS 'A'), the LXX has 'say'. Even if Ben Sira does not yet have a sure and clear idea of retribution after death, he several times stresses the importance of the hour of death (see 11:26–28). There could also be an advance in the Greek translation of the Hebrew text, which merely says, 'In everything you do, consider the end' (**בכל מעשיך זכור אחרית**); that is, be careful of the consequences of your actions. By the more precise 'your end', the LXX clearly envisages the last things.

Σοφία Σιραχ 8

- ¹ Μὴ διαμάχου μετὰ ἀνθρώπου δυνάστου,
μήποτε ἐμπέσης εἰς τὰς χεῖρας αὐτοῦ.
² μὴ ἔριξε μετὰ ἀνθρώπου πλουσίου,
μήποτε ἀντιστήσῃ σου τὴν ὀλκὴν·
πολλοὺς γὰρ ἀπώλεσεν τὸ χρυσίον
καὶ καρδίας βασιλέων ἐξέκλινεν.
³ μὴ διαμάχου μετὰ ἀνθρώπου γλωσσώδους
καὶ μὴ ἐπιστοιβάσῃς ἐπὶ τὸ πῦρ αὐτοῦ ξύλα.
⁴ μὴ πρόσπαιξε ἀπαιδεύτῳ,
ἵνα μὴ ἀτιμάζωνται οἱ πρόγονοί σου.
⁵ μὴ ὀνειδίξῃς ἄνθρωπον ἀποστρέφοντα ἀπὸ ἀμαρτίας·
μνήσθητι ὅτι πάντες ἐσμὲν ἐν ἐπιτίμοις.
⁶ μὴ ἀτιμάσῃς ἄνθρωπον ἐν γῆρα αὐτοῦ·
καὶ γὰρ ἐξ ἡμῶν γηράσκουσιν.
⁷ μὴ ἐπὶ χαιρὲ ἐπὶ νεκρῷ·
μνήσθητι ὅτι πάντες τελευτῶμεν.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 8

- ¹ Do not contend with the powerful,
or you may fall into their hands.
² Do not quarrel with the rich,
in case their resources outweigh yours.
For, gold has destroyed many,
and has swayed the hearts of kings.
³ Do not argue with a loudmouthed man
and do not heap wood on his fire.
⁴ Do not make fun of one who is ill bred,
or you may insult your ancestors.
⁵ Do not revile a repentant sinner;
remember that we are all guilty.
⁶ Do not despise anyone in old age;
after all, some of us too are growing old.
⁷ Do not gloat over anyone's death;
remember that we all end up dead.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 8

- ¹ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds a 2nd part to this verse: אל תריב עם קשה מ' [..] למה תפול בידו ('Do not fight with one harder than you; why fall by his hand?').
² The gold of the rich can function as a bribe.
³ The NJB has 'the loud of mouth' in place of 'a loudmouthed man'.
⁴ Curses such as this were common in the East.
⁵ 'Guilty' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (and the NJB); the NRSV, following the LXX, has 'deserve punishment'.
⁶ In place of 'some of us', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'we are all'.
⁷ The NJB ends with 'have to die' in place of 'end up dead', here following the WEBBE.

8 μὴ παρίδῃς διήγημα σοφῶν
καὶ ἐν ταῖς παροιμίαις αὐτῶν ἀναστρέφου·
ὅτι παρ' αὐτῶν μαθήσῃ παιδείαν
καὶ λειτουργῆσαι μεγιστᾶσιν.

9 μὴ ἀστόχει διηγήματος γερόντων,
καὶ γὰρ αὐτοὶ ἔμαθον παρὰ τῶν πατέρων αὐτῶν·
ὅτι παρ' αὐτῶν μαθήσῃ σύνεσιν
καὶ ἐν καιρῷ χρείας δοῦναι ἀπόκρισιν.

10 μὴ ἔκκαιε ἄνδρα καὶ ἁμαρτωλοῦ,
μὴ ἐμπυρρῇς ἐν πυρὶ φλογὸς αὐτοῦ.

11 μὴ ἐξαναστῇς ἀπὸ προσώπου ὑβριστοῦ,
ἵνα μὴ ἐγκαθίσῃ ὡς ἔνεδρον τῷ στόματί σου.

12 μὴ δανείσῃς ἀνθρώπῳ ἰσχυροτέρῳ σου·
καὶ ἐὰν δανείσῃς, ὡς ἀπολωλεκὸς γίνου.

13 μὴ ἐγγυήσῃς ὑπὲρ δυνάμιν σου·
καὶ ἐὰν ἐγγυήσῃς, ὡς ἀποτείσων φρόντιζε.

14 μὴ δικάζῃς μετὰ κριτοῦ·
κατὰ γὰρ τὴν δόξαν αὐτοῦ κρινούσιν αὐτῷ.

8 Do not scorn the discourse of the wise,
but make yourself familiar with their maxims;
for, from these you will learn the theory
and the art of serving the great.

9 Do not dismiss what the old men have to say,
for they too were taught by their fathers;
from them you will learn how to think,
and the art of the timely answer.

10 Do not kindle the coals of the sinner,
in case you scorch yourself in this blaze.

11 Refuse to be provoked by the insolent,
for fear that such a one tries to trap you in your words.

12 Do not lend to anyone who is stronger than you are;
if you do lend, resign yourself to loss.

13 Do not stand surety beyond your means;
if you do stand surety, be prepared to pay up.

14 Do not go to law with a judge,
since judgement will be given in his favour.

-
- 8 Ben Sira is aware that wisdom is a traditional matter and that, in earlier days, in Israel as in Egypt, it had been the qualification for being a government official, being the 'art of serving the great'.
- 9 An alternative translation for 'fathers' is 'ancestors'. The rabbis think highly of tradition, which they call 'the oral law' (see Dt 4:9, 11:19, Job 12:12, Ps 44:1, 78:3ff). Most books of the Bible formed part of this oral tradition before being committed to writing; this is notably true of the proverbs and maxims of the sages.
- 10 Lighting coals is an image for arousing passion.
- 11 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads: *אל תזוח מפני לץ להושיבו כאורב לפניך* ('Do not be friends with the mocker, lest he turn and ambush you.').
- 12 Ben Sira is cautious about loans and surety but not opposed to them (29:1-7), in contrast to Pr 6:1-5, 11:15.
- 13 Sefaria translates C.G. MS 'A' (*אל תערב יתר ממך ואם ערבת כמשלם*) as, "Be not surety above your ability; if you are surety, set it aside as if paid."
- 14 For the 2nd line, here following the NJB, the WEBBE has, "for, according to his honour, they will give judgement for him."

- ¹⁵ μετὰ τολμηροῦ μὴ πορεύου ἐν ὁδῷ,
ἵνα μὴ βαρύνηται κατὰ σοῦ.
αὐτὸς γὰρ κατὰ τὸ θέλημα αὐτοῦ ποιήσει,
καὶ τῇ ἀφροσύνῃ αὐτοῦ συναπολῇ.
¹⁶ μετὰ θυμώδους μὴ ποιήσης μάχην
καὶ μὴ διαπορεύου μετ' αὐτοῦ τὴν ἔρημον·
ὅτι ὡς οὐδὲν ἐν ὀφθαλμοῖς αὐτοῦ αἷμα,
καὶ ὅπου οὐκ ἔστιν βοήθεια, καταβαλεῖ σε.
¹⁷ μετὰ μωροῦ μὴ συμβουλευέου·
οὐ γὰρ δυνήσεται λόγον στέξαι.
¹⁸ ἐνώπιον ἀλλοτρίου μὴ ποιήσης κρυπτόν·
οὐ γὰρ γινώσκεις τί τέξεται.
¹⁹ παντὶ ἀνθρώπῳ μὴ ἔκφαινε σὴν καρδίαν,
καὶ μὴ ἀναφερέτω σοι χάριν.

- ¹⁵ Do not go travelling with a reckless man,
for fear he becomes burdensome to you.
He will act as the whim takes him
and you will both be ruined by his folly.
¹⁶ Do not argue with a quick-tempered man;
do not travel with him into the desert,
since blood counts for nothing in his eyes,
and, where there is no help, he will strike you down.
¹⁷ Do not ask a fool for advice,
since he will not be able to keep a secret.
¹⁸ Do no secret thing in a stranger's presence,
since you cannot tell what he will divulge.
¹⁹ Do not open your heart to all comers,
or you may drive away your happiness.

¹⁵ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'cruel' (or 'heartless', אכזרי) in place of 'reckless', here following the LXX (τολμηροῦ).

¹⁶ For the 2nd line, the NJB has, "do not go with him where there are no other people."

¹⁷ The NJB has 'confidence' in place of 'secret'.

¹⁸ In place of 'they will divulge', here following the NRSV, the NJB has 'use they will make of it'.

¹⁹ The 2nd line here follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (ואל תדיח מעליך הטובה) and the NRSV; the LXX (and NJB) has, "nor let him return a favour to you."

Σοφία Σιραχ 9

- ¹ Μὴ ζήλου γυναῖκα τοῦ κόλπου σου
μηδὲ διδάξης ἐπὶ σεαυτὸν παιδείαν πονηράν.
- ² μὴ δῶς γυναικὶ τὴν ψυχὴν σου
ἐπιβῆναι αὐτὴν ἐπὶ τὴν ἰσχύν σου.
- ³ μὴ ὑπάντα γυναικὶ ἐταιριζομένην,
μήποτε ἐμπέσης εἰς τὰς παγίδας αὐτῆς.
- ⁴ μετὰ ψαλλούσης μὴ ἐνδελέχιζε,
μήποτε ἀλῶς ἐν τοῖς ἐπιχειρήμασιν αὐτῆς.
- ⁵ παρθένον μὴ καταμάνθανε,
μήποτε σκανδαλισθῇς ἐν τοῖς ἐπιτιμίοις αὐτῆς.
- ⁶ μὴ δῶς πόρναις τὴν ψυχὴν σου,
ἵνα μὴ ἀπολέσης τὴν κληρονομίαν σου.
- ⁷ μὴ περιβλέπου ἐν ῥύμαις πόλεως
καὶ ἐν ταῖς ἐρήμοις αὐτῆς μὴ πλανῶ.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 9

- ¹ Do not be jealous of the wife you love;
do not teach her lessons in how to harm you.
- ² Do not put yourself in a woman's hands
or she may come to dominate you completely.
- ³ Do not keep company with a prostitute,
in case you get entangled in her snares.
- ⁴ Do not dally with a singing girl,
in case you get caught by her wiles.
- ⁵ Do not stare at a virgin,
in case you and she incur the same punishment.
- ⁶ Do not give your soul to whores,
or you will ruin your inheritance.
- ⁷ Keep your eyes to yourself in the streets of a town;
do not prowl about its unfrequented quarters.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 9

- ¹ The reader is enjoined not to be jealous but to be firm (v. 2).
- ² Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads: אל תקנא לאשה נפשך להדריכה על במותיך ("Do not be jealous of the wife of your soul, lest she trample upon your sanctuary." – the word translated 'sanctuary' more literally means 'high place' or even 'funeral mound').
- ³ In place of 'prostitute', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'foreign woman' (אִשָּׁה זָרָה). The text of vv. 3–4 is pointed (has vowels and accents added) in the MS but other verses of this chapter (as with the majority of that MS) are not.
- ⁴ The prohibitions of vv. 4–9 have various motive clauses, mostly practical. Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'harlot' (זוֹנָה) in place of 'singing girl' (although it is possible that the word can have either meaning),
- ⁵ The NJB has 'pretty girl' in place of 'virgin'.
- ⁶ In place of 'soul', here following the LXX (ψυχὴν) and the WEBBE, the NJB has 'heart'.
- ⁷ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads: להתנבל במראה עיניך ולשומם אחר ביתה, "Your eyes will make a fool of you over a beautiful woman and your house will become desolate."

8 ἀπόστρεψον ὀφθαλμὸν ἀπὸ γυναικὸς εὐμόρφου
καὶ μὴ καταμάνθανε κάλλος ἀλλότριον·
ἐν κάλλει γυναικὸς πολλοὶ ἐπλανήθησαν,
καὶ ἐκ τούτου φιλία ὡς πῦρ ἀνακαίεται.

9 μετὰ ὑπάνδρου γυναικὸς μὴ κάθου τὸ σύνολον
καὶ μὴ συμβολοκοπήσης μετ' αὐτῆς ἐν οἴνῳ,
μήποτε ἐκκλίνη ἡ ψυχὴ σου ἐπ' αὐτήν
καὶ τῷ πνεύματί σου ὀλίσθῃς εἰς ἀπώλειαν.

10 Μὴ ἐγκαταλίπῃς φίλον ἀρχαῖον,
ὁ γὰρ πρόσφατος οὐκ ἔστιν ἔφισος αὐτῷ·
οἶνος νέος φίλος νέος·
ἐὰν παλαιωθῇ, μετ' εὐφροσύνης πίεσαι αὐτόν.

11 μὴ ζηλώσης δόξαν ἀμαρτωλοῦ·
οὐ γὰρ οἶδας τί ἔσται ἡ καταστροφή αὐτοῦ.

12 μὴ εὐδοκήσῃς ἐν εὐδοκίᾳ ἀσεβῶν·
μνήσθητι ὅτι ἕως ἄδου οὐ μὴ δικαιωθῶσιν.

13 μακρὰν ἄπεχε ἀπὸ ἀνθρώπου,
ὃς ἔχει ἐξουσίαν τοῦ φονεύειν,
καὶ οὐ μὴ ὑποπτεύσῃς φόβον θανάτου·

8 Turn your eyes away from a handsome woman;
do not stare at beauty belonging to someone else.
Because of a woman's beauty, many have been undone;
this makes passion flare up like a fire.

9 Never sit down with a married woman,
or sit at table with her drinking wine,
in case you let your heart succumb to her
and you lose all self-control and slide to disaster.

10 Do not desert an old friend;
the new one will not be his match.
New friend, new wine;
when it grows old, you drink it with pleasure.

11 Do not envy the sinner his success;
for, you do not know what his end will be.

12 Do not take pleasure in what pleases the godless;
remember they will not go unpunished to hell.

13 Keep your distance from the strong man,
who has the power to kill,
and you will not be haunted by the fear of dying.

-
- 8 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads: לֹא יִפִּי לֹא יִפִּי לֹא יִפִּי ואל תביט חן ומאשת עין העלים, "Hide your eyes from a graceful woman, and do not ogle beauty not yours."
- 9 The best MSS omit the 1st line of this verse. For the last line, the NRSV reads: "and in blood (by your spirit) you may plunge to disaster."
- 10 For this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads וַיִּשָּׂן אַחֵר תַּחַת וישן אחר ת. חַדְשׁ אוֹהֵב חַדְשׁ חדש אוהב חדש [..]ק[.]: יי, with the word שָׁדַח written in small characters outside the main text area.
- 11 The NJB ends, "how that will end."
- 12 The literal translation of 'to hell' is 'to Hades' (ἕως ἄδου); for the 2nd line, the NRSV has 'remember they will not be held guiltless all their lives'.
- 13 Walking on 'the battlements' makes one a target for the arrows of the enemy; but the text of the LXX is unclear and Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'a net' (תֶּשֶׁת). Another reading for 'power' is 'authority'.

καὶ ἂν προσέλθῃς, μὴ πλημμελήσῃς,
 ἵνα μὴ ἀφέληται τὴν ζωὴν σου·
 ἐπίγνωθι ὅτι ἐν μέσῳ παγίδων διαβαίνεις
 καὶ ἐπὶ ἐπάλξεων πόλεως περιπατεῖς.
 14 κατὰ τὴν ἰσχύν σου στόχασαι τοὺς πλησίον
 καὶ μετὰ σοφῶν συμβουλεύου.
 15 μετὰ συνετῶν ἔστω ὁ διαλογισμός σου
 καὶ πᾶσα διήγησίς σου ἐν νόμῳ ὑψίστου.
 16 ἄνδρες δίκαιοι ἔστωσαν σύνδειπνοί σου,
 καὶ ἐν φόβῳ κυρίου ἔστω τὸ καύχημά σου.
 17 ἐν χειρὶ τεχνιτῶν ἔργον ἐπαινεσθήσεται,
 καὶ ὁ ἡγούμενος λαοῦ σοφὸς ἐν λόγῳ αὐτοῦ.
 18 φοβερὸς ἐν πόλει αὐτοῦ ἀνὴρ γλωσσώδης,
 καὶ ὁ προπετὴς ἐν λόγῳ αὐτοῦ μισηθήσεται.

If you do approach him, make no false move,
 or he may take your life.
 Realise that you are treading among tripwires,
 and that you are strolling on the battlements.
 14 As well as you can, aim to know your neighbours,
 and take counsel with the wise.
 15 For conversation, seek the intelligent;
 let all your discourse be on the Law of the Most High.
 16 Have the upright for your table companions,
 and let your pride be in fearing the Lord.
 17 Work from skilled hands will earn its praise,
 but a leader of the people must be skilful in words.
 18 A loudmouthed man is dangerous in his city;
 and he who is reckless in his speech will be hated.

14 For this verse, here following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, "Cultivate your neighbours to the best of your ability, and consult with the wise."

15 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads: עם נבון יהי חשבונך וכל סודך בינותם. ("With intelligent people should be your calculations, and all your secrets only between yourselves.")

16 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'God' (אלהים) in place of 'the Lord'.

17 This maxim draws a parallel between the workman, whose social value lies in his manual dexterity, and a head of state, who enforces his wishes by his eloquence. However, the text (here following the LXX) is uncertain: Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has: "Right is esteemed by skilful people and the leader of the people is skilful in speaking." (בחכמי ידים יחשך יושר ומוש [.] עמו חכם)

18 For this verse, here following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, "A chatterbox is a terror to his town; a loose talker is detested."

Σοφία Σιραχ 10

- ¹ Κριτής σοφός παιδεύσει τὸν λαὸν αὐτοῦ,
καὶ ἡγεμονία συνετοῦ τεταγμένη ἔσται.
² κατὰ τὸν κριτὴν τοῦ λαοῦ οὕτως
καὶ οἱ λειτουργοὶ αὐτοῦ,
καὶ κατὰ τὸν ἡγούμενον
τῆς πόλεως πάντες οἱ κατοικοῦντες αὐτήν.
³ βασιλεὺς ἀπαιδευτος ἀπολεῖ τὸν λαὸν αὐτοῦ,
καὶ πόλις οἰκισθήσεται ἐν συνέσει δυναστῶν.
⁴ ἐν χειρὶ κυρίου ἡ ἐξουσία τῆς γῆς,
καὶ τὸν χρήσιμον ἐγερεῖ εἰς καιρὸν ἐπ' αὐτῆς.
⁵ ἐν χειρὶ κυρίου εὐδοκία ἀνδρός,
καὶ προσώπῳ γραμματέως ἐπιθήσει δόξαν αὐτοῦ.
⁶ Ἐπὶ παντὶ ἀδικήματι μὴ μνηϊάσης τῷ πλησίον
καὶ μὴ προᾶσσε μὴδὲν ἐν ἔργοις ὕβρεως.
⁷ μισητὴ ἔναντι κυρίου καὶ ἀνθρώπων ὑπερηφανία,
καὶ ἐξ ἀμφοτέρων πλημμελὴς ἡ ἀδικία.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 10

- ¹ A wise judge educates his people,
and he makes his subjects understand order.
² As the magistrate is,
so will his officials be;
as the governor is,
so will be the inhabitants of his city.
³ An undisciplined king will be the ruin of his people;
a city owes its prosperity to the wisdom of its leaders.
⁴ The government of earth is in the hands of the Lord;
he sets the right leader over it at the right time.
⁵ Human success is in the hands of the Lord
and he invests the scribe with honour.
⁶ Do not resent you neighbour's every offence,
and never act in a fit of passion.
⁷ Pride is hateful to God and to humanity,
and injustice is abhorrent to both.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 10

- ¹ The NJB has 'sagacious ruler' in place of 'wise judge' (see v. 2).
² Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reverses the order of vv. 2 & 3.
³ In place of 'undisciplined', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has פרוץ ('wild' or 'profligate').
⁴ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reverses the order of vv. 4 & 5.
⁵ The NRSV, following Cairo Genizah MS 'A', has 'lawgiver' (מחוקק) in place of 'scribe', here following the LXX (γραμματέως) and NJB.
⁶ In vv. 6–18 (concerning arrogance and pride, especially in rulers), Ben Sira may have in mind certain Ptolemaic and Seleucid kings; but several verses (12, 18) apply to ordinary people.
⁷ The WEBBE has 'arrogance' in place of 'injustice'.

⁸ βασιλεία ἀπὸ ἔθνους εἰς ἔθνος μετὰγεται
διὰ ἀδικίας καὶ ὕβρεις καὶ χρήματα.

...

⁹ τί ὑπερηφανεύεται γῆ καὶ σποδός;
ὅτι ἐν ζωῇ ἔρριψα τὰ ἐνδόσθια αὐτοῦ.

¹⁰ μακρὸν ἀρρώστημα, σκώπτει ἰατρός·
καὶ βασιλεὺς σήμερον, καὶ αὐριον τελευτήσῃ.

¹¹ ἐν γὰρ τῷ ἀποθανεῖν ἄνθρωπον
κληρονομήσῃ ἐρπετὰ καὶ θηρία καὶ σκώληκας.

¹² Ἀρχὴ ὑπερηφανίας ἀνθρώπου ἀφίστασθαι ἀπὸ κυρίου,
καὶ ἀπὸ τοῦ ποιήσαντος αὐτὸν ἀπέστη ἡ καρδιά αὐτοῦ.

¹³ ὅτι ἀρχὴ ὑπερηφανίας ἁμαρτία,
καὶ ὁ κρατῶν αὐτῆς ἐξομβρήσει βδέλυγμα·
διὰ τοῦτο παρεδόξασεν κύριος τὰς ἐπαγωγὰς
καὶ κατέστρεψεν εἰς τέλος αὐτοῦς.

¹⁴ θρόνους ἀρχόντων καθεῖλεν ὁ κύριος
καὶ ἐκάθισεν πραεῖς ἀντ' αὐτῶν·

⁸ Sovereignty passes from nation to nation
because of injustice, arrogance and money.

*Nothing is more wicked than one who loves money;
for, such a person puts his own soul up for sale.*

⁹ Why are dust and ashes proud?
Even in life, their entrails are repellent.

¹⁰ “The smallest illness,” laments the doctor;
a king today is a corpse tomorrow.

¹¹ For, in death, the portion of all alike will be
insects, vermin and worms.

¹² The first stage of pride is to desert the Lord
and to turn one’s heart away from one’s Maker.

¹³ Since the first stage of pride is sin,
whoever clings to it will pour forth filth.
This is why the Lord inflicts strange calamities
on such people, utterly destroying them.

¹⁴ The Lord has turned mighty princes off their thrones
and seated the humble there instead.

⁸ The 3rd & 4th lines, following the Greek 248 MSS, are not present in the NJB, and in the NRSV only as a footnote.

⁹ The text of the 2nd line has been emended, following the Syro-Hexaplar text and commentaries; the LXX is obscure – ‘a being who, living, throws his intestines’ – and Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ is corrupt and unintelligible (אשר בחייו יורם גויו).

¹⁰ The 1st line follows Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ (שמץ מחלה יצהיב רופא); the meaning of the LXX is uncertain. The verse seems to mean that it is useless to try to keep people alive, death being inevitable (but cf. Ch. 38).

¹¹ The NJB, following the LXX, has ‘wild animals’ in place of ‘vermin’, here following Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ (ורמש).

¹² CG MS ‘A’ reads: תחלת גאון אדם מועז ומעשהו יסור מלבו. (“The beginning of pride is impudence, and to those who made him he turns away his heart.”)

¹³ For ‘strange calamities’, here following the WEBBE, the NJB has ‘unexpected punishments’.

¹⁴ Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ has ‘God’ (אלהים) in place of ‘The Lord’ (ὁ κύριος).

¹⁵ ῥίζας ἐθνῶν ἐξέτιλεν ὁ κύριος
καὶ ἐφύτευσεν ταπεινοὺς ἀντ' αὐτῶν.
¹⁶ χώρας ἐθνῶν κατέστρεψεν ὁ κύριος
καὶ ἀπώλεσεν αὐτὰς ἕως θεμελίων γῆς.
¹⁷ ἐξῆρεν ἐξ αὐτῶν καὶ ἀπώλεσεν αὐτοὺς
καὶ κατέπαυσεν ἀπὸ γῆς τὸ μνημόσυνον αὐτῶν.
¹⁸ οὐκ ἔκτισται ἀνθρώποις ὑπερηφανία
οὐδὲ ὀργὴ θυμοῦ γεννήμασιν γυναικῶν.
¹⁹ Σπέρμα ἔντιμον ποῖον;
σπέρμα ἀνθρώπου.
σπέρμα ἔντιμον ποῖον;
οἱ φοβούμενοι τὸν κύριον.
σπέρμα ἄτιμον ποῖον;
σπέρμα ἀνθρώπου.
σπέρμα ἄτιμον ποῖον;
οἱ παραβαίνοντες ἐντολάς.
²⁰ ἐν μέσῳ ἀδελφῶν ὁ ἡγούμενος αὐτῶν ἔντιμος,
καὶ οἱ φοβούμενοι κύριον ἐν ὀφθαλμοῖς αὐτοῦ.

¹⁵ The Lord has uprooted the *proud* nations
and planted the lowly in their place.
¹⁶ The Lord has overthrown the lands of the nations
and destroyed them to the foundations of the earth.
¹⁷ Some, he has taken away and destroyed them
and blotted out their memory from the earth.
¹⁸ Pride was not created for men,
nor furious rage for those born of woman.
¹⁹ What race deserves honour?
The human race.
What race deserves honour?
Those who fear the Lord.
What race deserves contempt?
The human race.
What race deserves contempt?
Those who break the Law.
²⁰ A leader is worthy of honour by his brothers,
and those who fear the Lord have honour in his eyes.

-
- ¹⁵ The NJB omits 'nations' and the NRSV omits 'proud'. The LXX has 'nations' (which is very similar to 'proud' in written Hebrew) but *Cairo Genizah* MS 'A' lacks this verse.
¹⁶ For the 2nd line, *Cairo Genizah* MS 'A' has 'and their roots to the earth's core he exterminated' (ושרשם עד ארץ קרקע).
¹⁷ The NJB opens, "Sometimes he has taken them away;" here, we follow the WEBBE.
¹⁸ In place of 'men', the NJB has 'human beings'.
¹⁹ This key verse is developed in what follows. The surviving text of *Cairo Genizah* MS 'B' begins at this verse.
²⁰ For the 2nd line, here following the LXX, *Cairo Genizah* MS 'A' has 'and he will see God with [his eyes]' ([...] וירא אלהים בעי) and MS 'B' has 'and he will see God honoured more than himself' (וירא אלהים נכבד ממנו).

...

- 22** πλούσιος καὶ ἔνδοξος καὶ πτωχός,
τὸ καύχημα αὐτῶν φόβος κυρίου.
- 23** οὐ δίκαιον ἀτιμάσαι πτωχὸν συνετόν,
καὶ οὐ καθήκει δοξάσαι ἄνδρα ἁμαρτωλόν.
- 24** μεγιστὰν καὶ κριτῆς καὶ δυνάστης δοξασθήσεται,
καὶ οὐκ ἔστιν αὐτῶν
τις μείζων τοῦ φοβουμένου τὸν κύριον.
- 25** οἰκέτῃ σοφῷ ἐλεύθεροι λειτουργήσουσιν,
καὶ ἄνθρωπος ἐπιστήμων οὐ γογγύσει.
- 26** Μὴ σοφίζου ποιῆσαι τὸ ἔργον σου
καὶ μὴ δοξάζου ἐν καιρῷ στενοχωρίας σου.
- 27** κρείσσων ἐργαζόμενος καὶ περισσεύων ἐν πᾶσιν
ἢ περιπατῶν δοξαζόμενος καὶ ἀπορῶν ἄρτων.
- 28** τέκνον, ἐν πραύτητι δόξασον τὴν ψυχὴν σου
καὶ δὸς αὐτῇ τιμὴν κατὰ τὴν ἀξίαν αὐτῆς.

- 21** *The fear of the Lord is the beginning of acceptance,
but the beginning of rejection is stubbornness and pride.*
- 22** The rich, the noble and the poor:
let them pride themselves on fearing the Lord.
- 23** It is not right to despise one who is poor but intelligent,
and it is not good to glorify a man who is a sinner.
- 24** Magnate, and magistrate, and potentate:
all are worthy of honour,
but none is greater than the one who fears the Lord.
- 25** A wise slave will have free men waiting on him,
and the enlightened will not complain.
- 26** Do not try to be smart when you do your work;
do not put on airs when you are in difficulty.
- 27** Better the hardworking who has plenty of everything
than he who boasts and lacks bread.
- 28** My son, be modest in your self-esteem,
and value yourself at your proper worth.

²¹ This verse follows the Greek 248 MS; it is present in the NRSV, WEBBE & NJB only as a footnote; Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'B' also lack the verse.

²² For the 1st line, Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' [& 'B'] read 'Sojourner and scoundrel [wayfarer], foreigner and poor man' (גר זזר [זר] נכרי ורש).

²³ In place of 'glorify a man', the NJB has 'honour one'.

²⁴ The text of the last line is missing from Cairo Genizah MS 'B', due to a tear in the parchment.

²⁵ Compare this verse with Paul's remarks on slavery (Ga 3:28, Col 3:11, Phm 16). After the 1st line, Cairo Genizah MS 'B' inserts the text of 7:21 (reading עבד משכיל חביב כנפ ש) but in a smaller script.

²⁶ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'and do not extol yourself [in your time of need]' (גדול מירא אלהים) [...]).

²⁷ For the 2nd line, here following the WEBBE, the NJB has, "than the pretentious at a loss for a meal."

²⁸ Humility is not false grovelling.

²⁹ τὸν ἁμαρτάνοντα εἰς τὴν ψυχὴν αὐτοῦ τίς δικαιώσει;
καὶ τίς δοξάσει τὸν ἀτιμάζοντα τὴν ζωὴν αὐτοῦ;
³⁰ πτωχὸς δοξάζεται δι' ἐπιστήμην αὐτοῦ,
καὶ πλούσιος δοξάζεται διὰ τὸν πλοῦτον αὐτοῦ.
³¹ ὁ δεδοξασμένος ἐν πτωχείᾳ, καὶ ἐν πλούτῳ ποσαχῶς;
καὶ ὁ ἄδοξος ἐν πλούτῳ, καὶ ἐν πτωχείᾳ ποσαχῶς;

²⁹ Who can justify one who inflicts injuries on himself,
or respect one who is full of self-contempt?
³⁰ A poor man is honoured for his knowledge
and a rich man is honoured for his riches.
³¹ Honoured in poverty – how much more in wealth!
Dishonoured in wealth – how much more in poverty!

²⁹ At the start of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'B' adds '(My) son' (cf. v. 28) but MS 'A' does not have this word (בני).

³⁰ The NJB has a rather shorter version of this verse: "The poor is honoured for wit, and the rich for wealth."

³¹ At the end of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'B' adds the following line: 'He who is honoured in his poverty, in wealth he is further respected; and he who is humbled in his wealth, how much more is he humbled in poverty?' (המתכבד בדלותו בעשרו והנקלה יתר והנקלה בעשרו בדלותו נקלה יתר); the line is lacking a column divider (as the vast majority of the lines in that MS have). MS 'A' has a similar addition but the text is partially obscured.

Σοφία Σιραχ ΙΙ

- ¹ σοφία ταπεινοῦ ἀνυψώσει κεφαλὴν αὐτοῦ
καὶ ἐν μέσῳ μεγιστάνων καθίσει αὐτόν.
- ² Μὴ αἰνέσης ἄνδρα ἐν κάλλει αὐτοῦ
καὶ μὴ βδελύξῃ ἄνθρωπον ἐν ὁράσει αὐτοῦ.
- ³ μικρὰ ἐν πετεινοῖς μέλισσα,
καὶ ἀρχὴ γλυκασμάτων ὁ καρπὸς αὐτῆς.
- ⁴ ἐν περιβολῇ ἱματίων μὴ καυχῆσθαι
καὶ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ δόξης μὴ ἐπαίρου·
ὅτι θαυμαστὰ τὰ ἔργα κυρίου,
καὶ κρυπτὰ τὰ ἔργα αὐτοῦ ἀνθρώποις.
- ⁵ πολλοὶ τύραννοι ἐκάθισαν ἐπὶ ἐδάφους,
ὁ δὲ ἀνυπονόητος ἐφόρεσεν διάδημα.
- ⁶ πολλοὶ δυνάσται ἡτιμάσθησαν σφόδρα,
καὶ ἔνδοξοι παρεδόθησαν εἰς χεῖρας ἐτέρων.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 11

- ¹ The wisdom of the lowly will lift up his head,
and make him sit in the midst of great men.
- ² Do not praise anyone for good looks,
nor dislike a man for mere appearance.
- ³ Small among winged creatures is the bee
but her produce is the sweetest of the sweet.
- ⁴ Do not boast about wearing fine clothes,
and do not grow proud when people honour you;
For, the works of the Lord are wonderful
but hidden from human beings.
- ⁵ Many monarchs have been made to sit on the ground,
and the person nobody thought of has worn the crown.
- ⁶ Many influential people have been utterly disgraced,
and men of renown have fallen into the others' hands.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 11

- ¹ For this verse, here following the WEBBE, the NJB has, "Wisdom enables the poor to lift their heads high, and gives to the poor a place with the great."
- ² For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MSS 'A'/'B' read, ואל תתעב אדם מכעזב במראה ('and do not loathe a man [who is] ugly in appearance').
- ³ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MSS 'A'/'B' read, וראש תנובות פריה ('but first among fruit is her produce'); MS 'B' adds the following (which seems like a dittography): אליל בעוף דבורה וראש תנובות פריה.
- ⁴ The NJB lacks the 1st line, here following the LXX (and NRSV); for the first 2 lines, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has, 'Do not jeer at anyone in rags, and do not mock anyone who is in trouble' (בועטה אזור אל תהתל ואל תקלס במרירי יום). The meaning of 'hidden' in the last line is 'unseen and unforeseeable': one turn of the wheel and all conditions are reversed (cf. 1S 2:8, Job 12:17-19, Ps 113:7).
- ⁵ An alternative translation for 'made to sit on the ground' is 'have been put on the pavement' (having reigned), which would give an antithetic parallel, but Cairo Genizah MS 'A', רבים נדכאים ישבו על כסא ('many humbled persons have ascended thrones') supports the reading adopted here. A more literal translation for 'monarchs' is 'tyrants'.
- ⁶ For the 2nd line, here following the WEBBE, the NJB has 'and prominent people have fallen into the power of others'.

7 *Πρὶν ἐξετάσης, μὴ μέμψῃ·
νόησον πρῶτον καὶ τότε ἐπιτίμα.*

8 *πρὶν ἢ ἀκοῦσαι μὴ ἀποκρίνου
καὶ ἐν μέσῳ λόγων μὴ παρεμβάλλου.*

9 *περὶ πράγματος, οὗ οὐκ ἔστιν σοι χρεία, μὴ ἔριζε
καὶ ἐν κρίσει ἀμαρτωλῶν μὴ συνέδρευε.*

10 *Τέκνον, μὴ περὶ πολλὰ ἔστωσαν αἱ πράξεις σου·
ἐὰν πληθύνῃς, οὐκ ἀθωωθήσῃ·
καὶ ἐὰν διώκῃς, οὐ μὴ καταλάβῃς·
καὶ οὐ μὴ ἐκφύγῃς διαδράς.*

11 *ἔστιν κοπιῶν καὶ πονῶν καὶ σπεύδων,
καὶ τόσῳ μᾶλλον ὑστερεῖται.*

12 *ἔστιν νωθρὸς προσδεόμενος ἀντιλήμψεως,
ὑστερῶν ἰσχύι καὶ πτωχεῖα περισσεύει·
καὶ οἱ ὀφθαλμοὶ κυρίου ἐπέβλεψαν αὐτῷ εἰς ἀγαθά,
καὶ ἀνώρθωσεν αὐτὸν ἐκ ταπεινώσεως αὐτοῦ*

13 *καὶ ἀνύψωσεν κεφαλὴν αὐτοῦ,
καὶ ἀπεθαύμασαν ἐπ' αὐτῷ πολλοί.*

7 Do not find fault before making thorough enquiry;
first understand, then give reprimand.

8 Listen before you answer,
and do not interrupt a speech before it is finished.

9 Don't argue about a matter that does not concern you;
don't interfere in the quarrels of sinners.

10 My son, do not take on a great amount of business;
for, if you meddle much, you will not be unpunished.
Hurry as fast as you can; yet you will never arrive,
nor will you escape by running away.

11 There is one who toils, labours, and hurries,
and is left even more behind.

12 There is the slow kind of person, needing help,
poor in possessions and rich in poverty;
and the Lord turns a favourable eye on him,
lifts him out of his wretched condition,

13 and lifts up his head,
so that many may marvel at him.

7 The NJB has 'reflect' in place of 'understand', here following the WEBBE.

8 At the opening of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds '[My] son' (בְּנִי).

9 After this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'B' has a blank line.

10 The 3rd & 4th lines here follow the LXX; Cairo Geniza MS 'A' has **בני אם לא תרוץ לא תגיע ואם לא תבקש לא תמצא** ('If you do not run you will not achieve; if you do not seek, you will not find'). The C.G. MS 'B' is damaged from here to 15:1 but what text remains seems to support MS 'A'.

11 For this verse, here following the WEBBE (and LXX), the NJB has, "Some people work very hard at top speed, only to find themselves falling further behind." Cairo Genizah MS 'A' broadly concurs with the LXX, here.

12 In place of 'wretched condition', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'dusty stench' (מעפר צחנה).

13 The NJB reads, "and enables him to hold his head high, thus causing general astonishment."

¹⁴ ἀγαθὰ καὶ κακά, ζωὴ καὶ θάνατος,
πτωχεῖα καὶ πλοῦτος παρὰ κυρίου ἐστίν.

[.] כְּמָה וּשְׂכָל וְהִבִּין דְּבַר מִיָּי הוּא:
חֲטָא וּדְרָכִים יִשְׂרָאֵל מִיָּי הוּא:
שְׂכָלוֹת וְחוֹן [..] לְפִשְׁעִים נּוֹצְרָה
וּמְרַעִים רַעְיָה עַמָּם:

¹⁷ δόσις κυρίου παραμένει εὐσεβέσιν,
καὶ ἡ εὐδοκία αὐτοῦ εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα εὐοδωθήσεται.

¹⁸ ἔστιν πλουτῶν ἀπὸ προσοχῆς καὶ σφιγγίας αὐτοῦ,
καὶ αὕτη ἡ μερὶς τοῦ μισθοῦ αὐτοῦ·

¹⁹ ἐν τῷ εἰπεῖν αὐτόν Εὖρον ἀνάπαυσιν
καὶ νῦν φάγομαι ἐκ τῶν ἀγαθῶν μου,
καὶ οὐκ οἶδεν τίς καιρὸς παρελεύσεται
καὶ καταλείψει αὐτὰ ἑτέροις καὶ ἀποθανεῖται.

²⁰ Στῆθι ἐν διαθήκῃ σου καὶ ὁμίλει ἐν αὐτῇ
καὶ ἐν τῷ ἔργῳ σου παλαιώσῃ.

²¹ μὴ θαύμαζε ἐν ἔργοις ἀμαρτωλοῦ,
πίστευε δὲ κυρίῳ καὶ ἔμμενε τῷ πόνῳ σου·

¹⁴ Good and bad, life and death,
poverty and wealth, all come from the Lord.

¹⁵ Wisdom, prudence, and perception come from Yahweh,
error and straight paths come from him.

¹⁶ Folly and darkness were created with sinners
and those who do evil are with them.

¹⁷ To the devout, the Lord's gift remains constant,
and his favour will be there to lead them forever.

¹⁸ Others grow rich by pinching and scraping,
and here is the reward they receive for it:

¹⁹ Although they say, "Now I can sit back
and enjoy the benefit of what I have got,"
and do not know how long this will last
and will have to leave their goods to others and die.

²⁰ Be steadfast in your job and be doing it
and grow old in your work.

²¹ Do not admire the achievements of sinners,
trust the Lord and mind your own business;

¹⁴ For 'from the Lord', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' uses a 'triple-yod triangle' (מִיָּי), as it does consistently when referring to the Divine Name.

¹⁵ Vv. 15–16, here following Cairo Genizah MS 'A', the Peshitta, and the Greek 248 MS, are included in the NJB and NRSV only as footnotes.

¹⁶ For the 2nd line, here following Abegg, the NJB has, "for those who take pleasure in evil, evil grows old."

¹⁷ In place of 'devout', here following the LXX, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'upright' (צַדִּיק).

¹⁸ For the opening 'Others grow', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'There is one who grows'.

¹⁹ The NJB opens the last 2 lines with 'they' in place of 'and'.

²⁰ 'Your covenant' follows the LXX and the WEBBE; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' and the NJB have 'your job'.

²¹ For the last 2 lines, here following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, "for, it is a trifle in the eyes of the Lord, in a moment, suddenly to make the poor rich."

ὅτι κοῦφον ἐν ὀφθαλμοῖς κυρίου
 διὰ τάχους ἐξάπινα πλουτίσαι πένητα.
 22 εὐλογία κυρίου ἐν μισθῷ εὐσεβοῦς,
 καὶ ἐν ὥρᾳ ταχινῇ ἀναθάλλει εὐλογίαν αὐτοῦ.
 23 μὴ εἴπῃς Τίς ἐστὶν μου χρεία,
 καὶ τίνα ἀπὸ τοῦ νῦν ἔσται μου τὰ ἀγαθά;
 24 μὴ εἴπῃς Αὐτάρκη μοί ἐστιν,
 καὶ τί ἀπὸ τοῦ νῦν κακωθήσομαι;
 25 ἐν ἡμέρᾳ ἀγαθῶν ἀμνησία κακῶν,
 καὶ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ κακῶν οὐ μνησθήσεται ἀγαθῶν.
 26 ὅτι κοῦφον ἔναντι κυρίου ἐν ἡμέρᾳ τελευτῆς
 ἀποδοῦναι ἀνθρώπῳ κατὰ τὰς ὁδοὺς αὐτοῦ.
 27 κάκωσις ὥρας ἐπιλησμονὴν ποιεῖ τρυφῆς,
 καὶ ἐν συντελείᾳ ἀνθρώπου ἀποκάλυψις ἔργων αὐτοῦ.
 28 πρὸ τελευτῆς μὴ μακάριζε μηδὲνα,
 καὶ ἐν τέκνοις αὐτοῦ γνωσθήσεται ἀνὴρ.
 29 Μὴ πάντα ἄνθρωπον εἰσαγε εἰς τὸν οἶκόν σου·
 πολλὰ γὰρ τὰ ἐνεδρα τοῦ δολίου.

for, it is an easy thing in the sight of the Lord
 to swiftly and suddenly make a poor man rich.
 22 The blessing of the Lord is the reward of the devout;
 and, in a moment, God brings his blessing to flower.
 23 Do not say, "What use is there of me
 and what further good things can be mine?"
 24 Do not say, "I am self-sufficient,
 what disaster can affect me now?"
 25 In prosperous times, disasters are forgotten
 and, in times of disaster, no one remembers prosperity.
 26 For, it is a trifle for the Lord, on the day someone dies,
 to repay him as his conduct deserves.
 27 A moment's adversity, and pleasures are forgotten;
 in a person's last hour, his deeds will stand revealed.
 28 Call no one fortunate before his death;
 it is by his end that someone will be known.
 29 Do not bring everyone home with you;
 for, many are the traps of the crafty.

22 After 'is', the LXX adds 'in'; here, we follow Cairo Genizah MS 'A' in omitting the preposition.

23 For this verse, here following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, "Do not say, "What are my needs, how much shall I have in the future?""

24 For the 2nd line, here following the NJB, the WEBBE has, "What harm could happen to me now?"

25 An alternative reading is, "Disasters (to come) are forgotten ... no one remembers (the possibility of future) prosperity." Envisaging the future, the verse would be more congruent with the context but the translation would be somewhat forced.

26 The NJB opens with 'Yet' in place of 'For'.

27 For the 1st line, the WEBBE reads, "The affliction of an hour causes delights to be forgotten."

28 'By his end' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A'; the LXX has 'in his children' (ἐν τέκνοις αὐτοῦ).

29 At the end of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds ([...] כן בתיהם מלאים [עוף]) ('as a cage is filled with [birds], so are their houses filled with [...]').

30 *πέρδιξ θηρευτῆς ἐν καρτάλλῳ,
 οὕτως καρδία ὑπερηφάνου,
 καὶ ὡς ὁ κατάσκοπος ἐπιβλέπει πτῶσιν·*
 31 *τὰ γὰρ ἀγαθὰ εἰς κακὰ μεταστρέφων ἐνεδρεύει
 καὶ ἐν τοῖς αἰρετοῖς ἐπιθήσει μῶμον.*
 32 *ἀπὸ σπινθήρος πυρὸς πληθύνεται ἀνθρακιά,
 καὶ ἄνθρωπος ἁμαρτωλὸς εἰς αἷμα ἐνεδρεύει.*
 33 *πρόσεχε ἀπὸ κακούργου, πονηρὰ γὰρ τεκταίνει,
 μήποτε μῶμον εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα θῷ σοι.*
 34 *ἐνοίκισον ἀλλότριον, καὶ διαστρέψει σε ἐν ταραχαῖς
 καὶ ἀπαλλοτριώσει σε τῶν ἰδίων σου.*

30 Like a captive partridge in a cage,
 so is the heart of the proud;
 and, like a spy, he watches for your downfall,
 31 ever on the lookout, turning good into bad
 and finding fault with what is praiseworthy.
 32 From a spark of fire, a heap of many coals is kindled
 and the sinner lurks for the chance to spill blood.
 33 Beware of a scoundrel and his evil contrivances,
 in case he puts a smear on you forever.
 34 Give a home to a stranger and he will start trouble
 and estrange you from your own family.

-
- 30 The 2nd line here follows the LXX; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'he is in ambush to tear him like a wolf' (כ[ב]זאב ארב לטרף). Like a decoy bird placed in a trap, the heart of the proud lures his fellow into the snares of sin.
 31 C.G. MS 'A' reads 'from good to bad will he turn your crowds and, on your treasure, he will conspire' (טוב לרע יהפך [גר]גן ובמחמדיך יתן קשר).
 32 For the 1st line, here following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, "A hearth full of glowing coals starts from a single spark."
 33 The WEBBE has 'an evildoer' in place of 'a scoundrel', here following the NJB.
 34 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' inserts the text of 12:1 (אם טוב תדיע למי תטיב ויהי תקוה לטובתך) between the 2 lines of this verse.

Σοφία Σιραχ 12

- 1** Ἐὰν εὖ ποιῇς, γινῶθι τίνι ποιεῖς,
καὶ ἔσται χάρις τοῖς ἀγαθοῖς σου.
- 2** εὖ ποιήσον εὐσεβεῖ, καὶ εὐρήσεις ἀνταπόδομα,
καὶ εἰ μὴ παρ' αὐτοῦ, ἀλλὰ παρὰ τοῦ ὑψίστου.
- 3** οὐκ ἔσται ἀγαθὰ τῷ ἐνδελεχίζοντι εἰς κακὰ
καὶ τῷ ἐλεημοσύνην μὴ χαριζομένῳ.
- 4** δὸς τῷ εὐσεβεῖ καὶ μὴ ἀντιλάβη τοῦ ἁμαρτωλοῦ.
- 5** εὖ ποιήσον ταπεινῷ καὶ μὴ δῶς ἀσεβεῖ·
ἐμπόδισον τοὺς ἄρτους αὐτοῦ καὶ μὴ δῶς αὐτῷ,
ἵνα μὴ ἐν αὐτοῖς σε δυναστεύσῃ·
διπλάσια γὰρ κακὰ εὐρήσεις
ἐν πᾶσιν ἀγαθοῖς, οἷς ἂν ποιήσῃς αὐτῷ.
- 6** ὅτι καὶ ὁ ὑψιστος ἐμίσησεν ἁμαρτωλοὺς
καὶ τοῖς ἀσεβέσιν ἀποδώσει ἐκδίκησιν.
- 7** δὸς τῷ ἀγαθῷ καὶ μὴ ἀντιλάβη τοῦ ἁμαρτωλοῦ.
- 8** Οὐκ ἐκδικηθήσεται ἐν ἀγαθοῖς ὁ φίλος,
καὶ οὐ κρυβήσεται ἐν κακοῖς ὁ ἐχθρός.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 12

- 1** If you mean to do a kindness, choose the right person,
then your good deeds will not be wasted.
- 2** Do good to someone devout and you will be rewarded,
if not by that person, the certainly by the Most High.
- 3** No good will come to one who persists in evil,
or who refuses to give alms.
- 4** Give to the devout and do not go to the aid of a sinner.
- 5** Do good to the humble and give nothing to the godless.
Refuse him bread; do not give him any;
for, it might make him stronger than you are.
Then you would be repaid evil twice over
for all the good you had done him.
- 6** For the Most High himself detests sinners,
and will repay the wicked with what they deserve.
- 7** Give to the good, and do not go to the aid of a sinner.
- 8** In prosperity, a man's friend will not be fully tested
but, in adversity, you cannot mistake an enemy.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 12

- 1** While Ben Sira's advice in vv. 1-7 is positive, is also self-serving. The contrast between the sinners and the devout is sharply drawn.
- 2** In place of 'the Most High', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has the Divine Name (יְיָ).
- 3** Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads *אין טובה למנוח רשע וגם צדקה לא עשה* – "No for for the one who comforts the wicked; he has not even done a good action."
- 4** At the end of this verse, the Vg adds, "for, on the godless and the sinful, he (God) will inflict a punishment, reserving them for the day of punishment."
- 5** The Vg begins, "Give to the man who is good and do not receive the sinner."
- 6** Some MSS add 'and he is keeping them for the day of their judgement'.
- 7** Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks this verse, which is a near repeat of v. 4.
- 8** Another, more literal, reading of 'fully tested' (as WEBBE) is 'punished'.

⁹ ἐν ἀγαθοῖς ἀνδρὸς οἱ ἐχθροὶ αὐτοῦ ἐν λύπῃ,
καὶ ἐν τοῖς κακοῖς αὐτοῦ καὶ ὁ φίλος διαχωρισθήσεται.
¹⁰ μὴ πιστεύσης τῷ ἐχθρῷ σου εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα·
ὥς γὰρ ὁ χαλκὸς ἰοῦται, οὕτως ἡ πονηρία αὐτοῦ·
¹¹ καὶ ἐὰν ταπεινωθῇ καὶ πορεύηται συγκεκυφώς,
ἐπίστησον τὴν ψυχὴν σου καὶ φύλαξαι ἀπ' αὐτοῦ
καὶ ἔσῃ αὐτῷ ὡς ἐκμεμαχὼς ἔσοπτρον
καὶ γνώσῃ ὅτι οὐκ εἰς τέλος κατίωσεν.
¹² μὴ στήσης αὐτὸν παρὰ σεαυτῷ,
μὴ ἀνατρέψας σε στῇ ἐπὶ τὸν τόπον σου·
μὴ καθίσσης αὐτὸν ἐκ δεξιῶν σου,
μήποτε ζητήσῃ τὴν καζέδραν σου
καὶ ἐπ' ἐσχάτων ἐπιγνώσῃ τοὺς λόγους μου
καὶ ἐπὶ τῶν ῥημάτων μου κατανυγήσῃ.
¹³ τίς ἐλέησει ἐπασιδὸν ὀφιοόδηκτον
καὶ πάντας τοὺς προσάγοντας θηρίοις;
¹⁴ οὕτως τὸν προσπορευόμενον ἀνδρὶ ἀμαρτωλῷ
καὶ συμφυρόμενον ἐν ταῖς ἀμαρτίαις αὐτοῦ.
¹⁵ ὥραν μετὰ σοῦ διαμενεῖ,
καὶ ἐὰν ἐκκλίνῃς, οὐ μὴ καρτερήσῃ.

⁹ In a man's prosperity, his enemies are grieved;
and, in his adversity, even a friend will disappear.
¹⁰ Do not ever trust an enemy;
as bronze tarnishes, so does an enemy's malice.
¹¹ Though he humbles himself and walks bowed down,
still be careful and beware of him;
and be to him as one who has wiped a mirror
and you will find that his tarnish cannot last.
¹² Do not stand him beside you
in case he thrusts you out and takes your place.
Do not seat him on your right,
or he will be after your position,
and then you will remember what I have said
and sadly admit that I was right.
¹³ Who feels sorry for a snake charmer bitten by a snake,
or for those who come near to savage animals?
¹⁴ It is just so for one who consorts with a sinner,
and becomes an accomplice in his sins.
¹⁵ He will stay with you for a while
and, if you once give way, he will press his advantage.

-
- ⁹ The text of the 1st line follows the LXX; the C. G. MS 'A' ending, **גם שונא ריע** ('even the man who hates him is his friend'), is apter for the parallelism.
¹⁰ For 'bronze', here following the NJB, the WEBBE has 'copper'; another option is to read 'brass'.
¹¹ The 3rd & 4th lines here follow the LXX; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (**היה לו כמגלה רז ולא ימצא להשחיתך ודע אחרית קנאה**) reads, "Behave towards him as (towards) someone who reveals a secret; he will not be able to hurt you, and remember the consequences of jealousy."
¹² For the 1st line, the WEBBE has, "Do not set him next to you."
¹³ In place of 'come near to', the NJB has 'take risks with'.
¹⁴ For 'sinner' Abegg has 'proud woman', though the text of Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'violent man' (**אשת זדון**).
¹⁵ The NJB opens the 2nd line with 'but' in place of 'and'.

¹⁶ καὶ ἐν τοῖς χεῖλεσιν αὐτοῦ γλυκανεῖ ὁ ἐχθρὸς
καὶ ἐν τῇ καρδίᾳ αὐτοῦ
βουλεύσεται ἀνατρέψαι σε εἰς βόθρον·
ἐν ὀφθαλμοῖς αὐτοῦ δακρύσει ὁ ἐχθρὸς,
καὶ ἐὰν εὖρη καιρόν, οὐκ ἐμπλησθήσεται ἀφ' αἵματος.
¹⁷ κακὰ ἐὰν ὑπαντήσῃ σοι,
εὕρήσεις αὐτὸν πρότερον ἐκεῖ σου,
καὶ ὡς βοηθῶν ὑποσχάσει πτέρναν σου·
¹⁸ τὴν κεφαλὴν αὐτοῦ κινήσει
καὶ ἐπικροτήσῃ ταῖς χερσὶν αὐτοῦ
καὶ πολλὰ διαψιθυρίσει
καὶ ἀλλοιώσει τὸ πρόσωπον αὐτοῦ.

¹⁶ And, an enemy may have sweetness of his lips,
and, in his heart,
a scheme to throw you into the ditch.
An enemy may have tears in his eyes
but, if he gets a chance, he will want more blood.
¹⁷ If you meet with adversity,
you will find him there before you
and, pretending to help you, he will trip you up.
¹⁸ He will wag his head
and he will clap his hands;
he will whisper a lot
and his expression will change.

¹⁶ The NJB ends, “there will never be enough blood for him.”

¹⁷ In place of ‘adversity’, the NJB has ‘misfortune’.

¹⁸ Wagging the head was a gesture of derision (Job 16:4, Ps 22:7, 109:25, see Mt 27:39). For ‘clapping hands’, see Lm 2:15, Ezk 25:6, Na 3:19.

Σοφία Σιραχ 13

- 1 Ὁ ἀπτόμενος πίσεως μολυνθήσεται,
καὶ ὁ κοινωνῶν ὑπερηφάνῳ ὁμοιωθήσεται αὐτῷ.
- 2 βάρος ὑπὲρ σέ μὴ ἄρης
καὶ ἰσχυροτέρῳ σου καὶ πλουσιωτέρῳ μὴ κοινωνῶναι.
τί κοινωνήσῃ χύτρα πρὸς λέβητα;
αὕτη προσκρούσει, καὶ αὕτη συντριβήσεται.
- 3 πλούσιος ἠδίκησεν, καὶ αὐτὸς προσεनेβριμήσατο·
πτωχὸς ἠδικηται, καὶ αὐτὸς προσδεηθήσεται.
- 4 ἐὰν χρησιμεύσης, ἐργᾶται ἐν σοί·
καὶ ἐὰν ὑστερήσης, καταλείψει σε.
- 5 ἐὰν ἔχῃς, συμβιώσεταιί σοι
καὶ ἀποκενώσει σε, καὶ αὐτὸς οὐ πονέσει.
- 6 χρεῖαν ἔσχηκέν σου, καὶ ἀποπλανήσῃ σε
καὶ προσγελάσεταιί σοι καὶ δώσει σοι ἐλπίδα·
λαλήσῃ σοι καλὰ καὶ ἐρεῖ Τίς ἡ χρεῖά σου;
- 7 καὶ αἰσχυνεῖ σε ἐν τοῖς βρώμασιν αὐτοῦ,
ἕως οὗ ἀποκενώσῃ σε δὶς ἢ τρίς,
καὶ ἐπ' ἐσχάτων καταμωκήσεταιί σου·

WISDOM OF SIRACH 13

- 1 He who touches pitch gets dirty
and he who associates with the proud becomes as him.
- 2 Do not try to carry a burden too heavy for you;
do not associate with one mightier and richer than you.
Why put the clay pot next to the iron cauldron?
It will only break when they bang against each other.
- 3 The rich man does wrong and takes a high line;
the poor is wronged and apologises.
- 4 If you are useful, the rich will exploit you;
if you go bankrupt, he will desert you.
- 5 If you are well off, he will live with you;
he will clean you out without a single qualm.
- 6 He will come to you, greet you and give you hope;
he will speak politely to you
and say, "Is there anything you need?"
- 7 He will make you feel small at his dinner parties
and, having cleaned you out two or three times over,
will end by laughing at you.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 13

- 1 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has a 'paragraph break' after this verse – the next verse starts on a new line with a small indentation (~ 4 letters wide).
- 2 The comparison between the 'clay pot' and the 'iron cauldron' is classic, found earlier in Aesop.
- 3 In place of 'apologises', here following the WEBBE, the NJB has 'has to beg for pardon'.
- 4 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads *אם תכשר לו יעבד בך ואם תכרע יחמל עליך* ('If you seem fit to him, he will make you serve him; but, if you become worn out, he will take pity on you').
- 5 For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads *ולא יכאב לו וירשעך* ('but if you become poor, it will not grieve him at all').
- 6 At the start of this verse, the WEBBE (following Cairo Genizah MS 'A' – *צריך לו עמד*) adds, "Does he need you?"
- 7 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks 'two or', here following the LXX.

μετὰ ταῦτα ὄψεταιί σε καὶ καταλείψει σε
καὶ τὴν κεφαλὴν αὐτοῦ κινήσει ἐπὶ σοί.
⁸ πρόσεχε μὴ ἀποπλανηθῆς
καὶ μὴ ταπεινωθῆς ἐν ἀφροσύνῃ σου.
⁹ Προσκαλεσαμένου σε δυνάστου ὑποχωρῶν γίνου,
καὶ τόσῳ μᾶλλον σε προσκαλέσεται·
¹⁰ μὴ ἔμπιπτε, μὴ ἀπωσθῆς,
καὶ μὴ μακρὰν ἀφίστω, ἵνα μὴ ἐπιλησθῇς.
¹¹ μὴ ἔπεχε ἰσηγορεῖσθαι μετ' αὐτοῦ
καὶ μὴ πίστευε τοῖς πλείοσιν λόγοις αὐτοῦ·
ἐκ πολλῆς γὰρ λαλιᾶς πειράσει σε
καὶ ὡς προσγελῶν ἐξετάσει σε.
¹² ἀνελεήμων ὁ μὴ συντηρῶν λόγους
καὶ οὐ μὴ φείσεται περὶ κακώσεως καὶ δεσμῶν.
¹³ συντήρησον καὶ πρόσεχε σφοδρῶς,
ὅτι μετὰ τῆς πτώσεώς σου περιπατεῖς.
¹⁷ *audiens vero illa, quasi in somnis vide, et vigilabis.*
¹⁸ *Omni vita tua dilige Deum,
et invoca illum in salute tua.*

Afterwards, when he sees you, he will avoid you
and shake his head about you.
⁸ Take care you are not hoodwinked
and thus humiliated while you are enjoying yourself.
⁹ When a mighty man invites you, show reluctance,
and he will press his invitation all the more.
¹⁰ Do not press him, in case you are pushed aside,
and do not stand aloof, or you will be overlooked.
¹¹ Do not affect to treat him as an equal;
do not trust his flow of words.
All his talking is expressly meant to test you;
under cover of geniality, he will be weighing you up.
¹² Pitiless is anyone who retails gossip;
he will not spare you either blows or chains.
¹³ Be wary! Take very great care,
because you are walking with your own downfall.
¹⁴ *When you hear that in your sleep, wake up!
Love God through all your life,
and pray to him for your salvation.*

-
- ⁸ 'While you are enjoying yourself' follows the LXX (and NRSV); the NJB, following the Peshitta and Vg, has, 'through your own stupidity'. Cairo Genizah MS 'A', for this verse, "Beware of being too insolent; do not imitate fools." (השמר אל תרהב מאד ואל תדמה בַּחֲסִירֵי מַדֵּעַ)
- ⁹ The NJB has 'an influential person' in place of 'a mighty man', here following the WEBBE.
- ¹⁰ This verse is a good example of Ben Sira's moderation and irony.
- ¹¹ For the last line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads 'he laughs while probing you' (ושחק לך וחקרך).
- ¹² For the 2nd line, the WEBBE has, "He won't hesitate to harm and to bind."
- ¹³ The WEBBE ends, "you walk in danger of falling."
- ¹⁴ This verse, following the Vg & Greek 248 MS, is included in the NRSV & NJB only as a footnote; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' also lacks the verse.

¹⁵ Πᾶν ζῶον ἀγαπᾷ τὸ ὅμοιον αὐτῷ
καὶ πᾶς ἄνθρωπος τὸν πλησίον αὐτοῦ.
¹⁶ πᾶσα σὰρξ κατὰ γένος συνάγεται,
καὶ τῷ ὁμοίῳ αὐτοῦ προσκολληθήσεται ἀνὴρ.
¹⁷ τί κοινωνήσῃ λύκος ἀμνῷ;
οὕτως ἁμαρτωλὸς πρὸς εὐσεβῆ.
¹⁸ τίς εἰρήνην ὑαῖνη πρὸς κύνα;
καὶ τίς εἰρήνην πλουσίῳ πρὸς πένητα;
¹⁹ κυνήγια λεόντων ὄναγροι ἐν ἐρήμῳ.
οὕτως νομαὶ πλουσίων πτωχοί.
²⁰ βδέλυγμα ὑπερηφάνῳ ταπεινότης.
οὕτως βδέλυγμα πλουσίῳ πτωχός.
²¹ πλούσιος σαλευόμενος στηρίζεται ὑπὸ φίλων,
ταπεινὸς δὲ πεσὼν προσαπωθεῖται ὑπὸ φίλων.
²² πλουσίου σφαλέντος πολλοὶ ἀντιλήμπτορες.
ἐλάλησεν ἀπόρητα, καὶ ἐδिकाίωσαν αὐτόν.

¹⁵ Every living thing loves its own sort,
and every man his neighbour.
¹⁶ Every creature mixes with its kind,
and a man will stick to people like himself.
¹⁷ What does a wolf have in common with a lamb?
It is just so with sinner and devout.
¹⁸ What peace can there be between hyena and dog?
And what peace between rich and poor?
¹⁹ Wild desert donkeys are the prey of lions;
so too, the poor is the quarry of the rich.
²⁰ The proud thinks humility abhorrent;
so too, the rich man abominates a poor man.
²¹ When the rich stumbles, he is supported by friends;
when the poor falls, his friends push him away.
²² When the rich slips, there are many hands to catch him;
if he talks nonsense, he is congratulated.

¹⁵ The NJB has 'fellow' in place of 'neighbour', here following the WEBBE.

¹⁶ For the 2nd line, here following the WEBBE, the NJB has, "and human beings stick to their own sort."

¹⁷ At the end of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds **וכן עשיר אל איש נאצל** ('and so is the rich to a man that is destitute').

¹⁸ For Ben Sira, the precept to frequent only one's equals is an extension of the harmony of nature, and therefore congruent with the divine will. His condemnation of wealth is not absolute (see v. 24); his intention is to prevent the poor from being led astray by the wealthy and thus incurring the risk of being crushed.

¹⁹ For 'desert donkeys', the WEBBE has 'donkeys ... in the wilderness'.

²⁰ In place of 'a poor man', the NJB has 'the poor'.

²¹ The NRSV has 'humble' in place of 'poor'. This verse is presumably to be understood metaphorically; 'stumbles' can mean 'say silly things' (Hebrew 'speaks', cf. 14:1), and what follows shows that talking is the topic in hand.

²² For 'but no room is made for him', here following the NJB, the WEBBE has 'but no one listens to him'.

ταπεινὸς ἔσφαλεν, καὶ προσεπετίμησαν αὐτῷ·
 ἐφθέγγατο σύνεσιν, καὶ οὐκ ἐδόθη αὐτῷ τόπος.
 23 πλούσιος ἐλάλησεν, καὶ πάντες ἐσίγησαν
 καὶ τὸν λόγον αὐτοῦ ἀνύψωσαν ἕως τῶν νεφελῶν.
 πτωχὸς ἐλάλησεν καὶ εἶπαν Τίς οὗτος;
 καὶ προσκόψῃ, προσανατρέψουσιν αὐτόν.
 24 ἀγαθὸς ὁ πλοῦτος, ᾧ μὴ ἐστὶν ἁμαρτία,
 καὶ πονηρὰ ἡ πτωχεία ἐν στόματι ἀσεβοῦς.
 25 Καρδία ἀνθρώπου ἀλλοιοῖ τὸ πρόσωπον αὐτοῦ,
 εἴτε εἰς ἀγαθὰ εἴτε εἰς κακά.
 ...
 26 Ἰχνος καρδίας ἐν ἀγαθοῖς πρόσωπον ἱλαρόν,
 καὶ εὖρεσις παραβολῶν διαλογισμοὶ μετὰ κόπων.

The poor slips and is blamed for it;
 he may talk good sense, but no room is made for him.
 23 The rich speaks and everyone stops talking,
 and then they praise his discourse to the skies.
 The poor speaks and people say, "Who is this?"
 And, if he stumbles, they trip him up yet more.
 24 Wealth is good where there is no sin;
 poverty is evil, the godless say.
 25 A man's heart moulds his expression,
 whether for better or worse:
 ...
 26 Happy heart, cheerful expression;
 but wearisome work, inventing proverbs.

23 For the last line, the WEBBE reads, "If he stumbles, they will help to overthrow him."

24 Perhaps for 'is evil' (following the LXX), we should read, 'is commensurate with impiety'; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'is commensurate with insolence'. Wealth is not in itself bad, but merely dangerous.

25 The last part of this verse is omitted in the best MSS.

26 It is not easy to see the connexion between the 2 lines of this verse but the text is uncertain. For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads, 'meditations and preoccupations: sad thoughts' (ושיג ישיח מחשבת עמל).

Σοφία Σιραχ 14

- ¹ μακάριος ἀνὴρ,
ὃς οὐκ ὠλίσθησεν ἐν τῷ στόματι αὐτοῦ
καὶ οὐ κατενύγη ἐν λύπῃ ἁμαρτιῶν·
- ² μακάριος οὗ οὐ κατέγνω ἢ ψυχὴ αὐτοῦ,
καὶ ὃς οὐκ ἔπεσεν ἀπὸ τῆς ἐλπίδος αὐτοῦ.
- ³ Ἄνδρὶ μικρολόγῳ οὐ καλὸς ὁ πλοῦτος,
καὶ ἀνθρώπῳ βασκάνῳ ἵνα τί χρήματα;
- ⁴ ὁ συνάγων ἀπὸ τῆς ψυχῆς αὐτοῦ συνάγει ἄλλοις,
καὶ ἐν τοῖς ἀγαθοῖς αὐτοῦ τρυφήσουσιν ἕτεροι.
- ⁵ ὁ πονηρὸς ἑαυτῷ τίνι ἀγαθὸς ἔσται;
καὶ οὐ μὴ εὐφρανθήσεται ἐν τοῖς χρήμασιν αὐτοῦ.
- ⁶ τοῦ βασκαίνοντος ἑαυτὸν οὐκ ἔστιν πονηρότερος,
καὶ τοῦτο ἀνταπόδομα τῆς κακίας αὐτοῦ·
- ⁷ κὰν εὖ ποιῇ, ἐν λήθῃ ποιεῖ,
καὶ ἐπ' ἐσχάτων ἐκφαίνει τὴν κακίαν αὐτοῦ.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 14

- ¹ Blessed is the man
who has not sinned in speech
and who feels no remorse for sins.
- ² Blessed is he whose soul does not reproach him
and who has never given up hope.
- ³ Wealth is not the right thing for the niggardly,
and what use are possessions to the covetous?
- ⁴ He who hoards by stinting himself hoards for others,
and others will live sumptuously on his riches.
- ⁵ If someone is mean to himself, whom does he benefit?
He does not even enjoy what is his own.
- ⁶ No one is meaner than he who is mean to himself;
this is punishment for his wickedness.
- ⁷ If he does any good, he does it unintentionally
and, in the end, he himself reveals his wickedness.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 14

- ¹ The literal translation for 'sinned' is 'slipped'; the NRSV has 'blundered'. Many Psalms similarly celebrate the happiness of the pure in heart (e.g. Ps 1, 32, 119), of the wise (e.g. Ps 41), and of the devout (e.g. Ps 128) as opposed to those who are happy by the world's standards. This passage anticipates the Beatitudes in the Sermon on the Mount (Mt 5:1-12).
- ² The NJB has 'conscience' in place of 'soul', here following the WEBBE.
- ³ Vv. 3-10 describe the miser and his gate.
- ⁴ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'and a stranger shall revel in his goods' (ובטובתו יתבעבע זר).
- ⁵ For the 2nd line, the WEBBE reads, "He won't enjoy his possessions."
- ⁶ For the 2nd line, the NJB reads, "this is how his wickedness repays him."
- ⁷ Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks vv. 7-8.

8 πονηρὸς ὁ βασκαίνων ὀφθαλμῷ,
ἀποστρέφων πρόσωπον καὶ ὑπερορῶν ψυχάς.
9 πλεονέκτου ὀφθαλμὸς οὐκ ἐμπίπλαται μερίδι,
καὶ ἀδικία πονηρὰ ἀναξηραίνει ψυχὴν.
10 ὀφθαλμὸς πονηρὸς φθονερός ἐπ' ἄρτω
καὶ ἐλλιπὴς ἐπὶ τῆς τραπέζης αὐτοῦ.
11 Τέκνον, καθὼς ἐὰν ἔχῃς, εὖ ποιεῖ σεαυτὸν
καὶ προσφορὰς κυρίῳ ἀξίως πρόσαγε.
12 μνήσθητι ὅτι θάνατος οὐ χρονιεῖ
καὶ διαθήκη ἄδου οὐχ ὑπεδείχθη σοι.
13 πρίν σε τελευτῆσαι εὖ ποιεῖ φίλῳ
καὶ κατὰ τὴν ἰσχύν σου ἔκτεινον καὶ δὸς αὐτῷ.
14 μὴ ἀφυστερήσῃς ἀπὸ ἀγαθῆς ἡμέρας,
καὶ μερὶς ἐπιθυμίας ἀγαθῆς μὴ σε παρελθάτω.
15 οὐχὶ ἐτέρῳ καταλείψεις τοὺς πόνους σου
καὶ τοὺς κόπους σου εἰς διαίρεσιν κλήρου;

8 Wicked is the person who has an envious eye,
averting his face and careless of others' lives.
9 The eye of the grasping is not content with what he has;
greed shrivels up the soul.
10 The miser is grudging of bread;
there is famine at his table.
11 My son, treat yourself as well as you can afford,
and bring worthy offerings to the Lord.
12 Remember that death will not delay,
and that you have never seen Sheol's contract.
13 Be kind to your friend before you die;
and, within your means, reach out and give to him.
14 Do not refuse yourself the good things of today;
do not let your share of a desired good pass you by.
15 Will you not have to leave your fortune to another,
and your toils to be divided by lot?

8 The miser 'averts his face' from those who need his help.

9 'Greed' (the NRSV has 'greedy injustice') translates the conjectural 'the evil eye'; the LXX has 'bad iniquity' (possible orthographic confusion by the Greek translator; however, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' is different: חלקו ולוקח חלק רעהו מאבד חלקו – 'In the eye of the greedy, his portion is small; but he who takes his neighbour's portion wastes his own').

10 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds the following: עין טובה מרבה הלחם ומעין יבש יזל מים על השלחן ('the generous multiplies bread; even a dry well flows on his table').

11 In contrast to vv. 3–10, vv. 11–19 teach that riches are to be used generously, because there will be no opportunity after death (vv. 12,16).

12 The NRSV has 'decree of Hades' in place of 'Sheol's contract'; this probably refers to the decree assigning the date of death (Is 28:15,18).

13 For the 2nd line, here loosely following the WEBBE, the NJB has, "treat him as generously as you can afford."

14 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads the 2nd line very differently: אל תעבר וחמוד רע אל תחמוד. ("But do not encroach on a brother's portion (?) and do not covet the desirable things of a neighbour.")

15 In place of 'your toils', the NJB has 'the fruit of your labour'.

¹⁶ δὸς καὶ λαβὲ καὶ ἀπάτησον τὴν ψυχὴν σου,
 ὅτι οὐκ ἔστιν ἐν ᾧδου ζητῆσαι τρυφὴν.
¹⁷ πᾶσα σὰρξ ὡς ἱμάτιον παλαιοῦται·
 ἡ γὰρ διαθήκη ἀπ' αἰῶνος Θανάτῳ ἀποθανῇ.
¹⁸ ὡς φύλλον θάλλον ἐπὶ δένδρῳ δασέος,
 τὰ μὲν καταβάλλει, ἄλλα δὲ φύει,
 οὕτως γενεὰ σαρκὸς καὶ αἵματος,
 ἡ μὲν τελευτᾷ, ἑτέρα δὲ γεννᾶται.
¹⁹ πᾶν ἔργον σηπόμενον ἐκλείπει,
 καὶ ὁ ἐργαζόμενος αὐτὸ μετ' αὐτοῦ ἀπελεύσεται.
²⁰ Μακάριος ἀνὴρ, ὃς ἐν σοφίᾳ μελετήσῃ
 καὶ ὃς ἐν συνέσει αὐτοῦ διαλεχθήσεται,
²¹ ὁ διανοούμενος τὰς ὁδοὺς αὐτῆς ἐν καρδίᾳ αὐτοῦ
 καὶ ἐν τοῖς ἀποκρύφοις αὐτῆς ἐννοηθήσεται.
²² ἔξελθε ὀπίσω αὐτῆς ὡς ἰχνευτῆς
 καὶ ἐν ταῖς ὁδοῖς αὐτῆς ἐνέδρευε.

¹⁶ Give and receive, enjoy yourself –
 there are no pleasures to be found in Sheol.
¹⁷ Like clothes, all flesh will wear out;
 the age-old law is, “Everyone must die.”
¹⁸ Like foliage growing on a bushy tree,
 some leaves falling, others growing,
 so are the generations of flesh and blood;
 one dies, another is born.
¹⁹ Every achievement rots away and perishes,
 and with it goes its author.
²⁰ Happy is anyone who meditates on wisdom
 and reasons with intelligence.
²¹ He studies her ways in his heart
 and ponders her secrets.
²² He pursues her like a hunter
 and lies in wait by her path.

-
- ¹⁶ At the end of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds **אלהים עשה (לפני)** *וכל דבר שיפה לעשות* ('and whatever is seemly to do, do it before God').
¹⁷ The 2nd line here follows the LXX (and NJB); Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (and the NRSV) has **והוק עולם גוע יגועו**, "for the decree from of old is, "You must die!"
¹⁸ In place of 'dies', the WEBBE has 'comes to an end'.
¹⁹ For this verse (here following the LXX), Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads, "All men's deeds are destined to perish and the works of his hands will follow him." (כל מעשיו רקוב ירקבו ופעל ידיו ימשך אחריו) Rv 14:13 transforms this notion; a person's works will follow him into the glory of a new life. Whereas Qoheleth finds this perplexing and even outrageous, Ben Sira treats it as a lesson in detachment.
²⁰ Vv. 20–27 teach that one should pursue Wisdom as a beloved, with intensity and resolution. In place of 'meditates on', some MSS have 'dies in'.
²¹ Cf. Ps 119, especially vv. 15, 23 & 148, on the happiness derived from meditating on the Law. Here, the object of study is wisdom, which is to be found notably in the proverbs and maxims of the sages.
²² For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'and lurking at her entrances' (**וכל מבואיה ירצד**).

²³ ὁ παρακύπτων διὰ τῶν θυρίδων αὐτῆς
καὶ ἐπὶ τῶν θυρωμάτων αὐτῆς ἀκροάσεται,
²⁴ ὁ καταλύων σύνεγγυς τοῦ οἴκου αὐτῆς
καὶ πῆξει πάσσαλον ἐν τοῖς τοίχοις αὐτῆς,
²⁵ στήσει τὴν σκηνὴν αὐτοῦ κατὰ χεῖρας αὐτῆς
καὶ καταλύσει ἐν καταλύματι ἀγαθῶν,
²⁶ θήσει τὰ τέκνα αὐτοῦ ἐν τῇ σκέπῃ αὐτῆς
καὶ ὑπὸ τοὺς κλάδους αὐτῆς αὐλισθήσεται,
²⁷ σκεπασθήσεται ὑπ' αὐτῆς ἀπὸ καύματος
καὶ ἐν τῇ δόξῃ αὐτῆς καταλύσει.

²³ He peeps in at her windows
and listens at her doors.
²⁴ He lodges close to her house
and fixes his peg in her wall.
²⁵ He pitches her tent at her side
and will lodge in a lodging where good things are.
²⁶ He sets his children in her shade
and camps beneath her branches.
²⁷ He is sheltered by her from the heat,
and, in her glory, he makes his home.

²³ Compare the 2nd line with the *Cairo Genizah* addition to v. 22.

²⁴ Several images are used in this passage for the search for wisdom: the hunter who pursues her (v. 22), the spy who tries to overhear what she is saying (v. 23) and the nomad who camps in her shadow (vv. 24–27).

²⁵ For the 2nd line, here following the WEBBE, the NJB reads, “and occupies an excellent lodging.”

²⁶ For the 1st line, *Cairo Genizah* MS ‘A’ reads, ‘and he will set his nest on her bough’ (וישים קנו בעופיה).

²⁷ The ‘glory’ (*Cairo Genizah* MS ‘A’ has ‘in her habitations’ – ובמענותיה) possibly refers to the Cloud that manifested the presence of Yahweh (cf. Ex 16:10 and #Ex 24:16), the *Shekinah* (Presence) of Rabbinical writings.

Σοφία Σιραχ 15

- 1 Ὁ φοβούμενος κύριον ποιήσει αὐτό,
καὶ ὁ ἐγκρατὴς τοῦ νόμου καταλήμψεται αὐτήν·
- 2 καὶ ὑπαντήσεται αὐτῷ ὡς μήτηρ
καὶ ὡς γυνὴ παρθενίας προσδέξεται αὐτόν·
- 3 ψωμιεῖ αὐτὸν ἄρτον συνέσεως
καὶ ὕδωρ σοφίας ποτίσει αὐτόν·
- 4 στηριχθήσεται ἐπ' αὐτήν καὶ οὐ μὴ κλιθῇ,
καὶ ἐπ' αὐτῆς ἐφέξει καὶ οὐ μὴ καταισχυνθῇ·
- 5 καὶ ὑψώσει αὐτὸν παρὰ τοὺς πλησίον αὐτοῦ
καὶ ἐν μέσῳ ἐκκλησίας ἀνοίξει τὸ στόμα αὐτοῦ·
- 6 εὐφροσύνην καὶ στέφανον ἀγαλλιάματος εὐρήσει
καὶ ὄνομα αἰῶνος κατακληρονομήσει.
- 7 οὐ μὴ καταλήμψονται αὐτήν ἄνθρωποι ἀσύνητοι,
καὶ ἄνδρες ἀμαρτωλοὶ οὐ μὴ ἰδωσιν αὐτήν·
- 8 μακράν ἐστιν ὑπερηφανίας,
καὶ ἄνδρες ψεῦσται οὐ μὴ μνησθήσονται αὐτῆς.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 15

- 1 Whoever fears the Lord will act like this,
and whoever grasps the Law will receive wisdom.
- 2 She will come to meet him like a mother,
and receive him like a virgin bride.
- 3 She will give him the bread of understanding to eat
and the water of wisdom to drink.
- 4 He will lean on her and will not fall;
and he will rely on her and not be put to shame.
- 5 And she will raise him high above his neighbours,
and, in full assembly, she will open his mouth.
- 6 He will find happiness and a crown of joy;
and he will inherit an everlasting name.
- 7 Fools will not gain possession of her,
nor will sinners set eyes on her.
- 8 She stands remote from pride
and liars cannot remember her.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 15

- 1 The LXX has 'her' in place of 'wisdom'. Jr 2:8 speaks of four official functions: priest, lawyer, prince and prophet. The 'man who grasps the Law' belongs to the second of these classes: he is the 'scribe' or 'doctor' of the Law, who became increasingly important in Judaism (see #Ezr 7:6).
- 2 In place of 'a virgin bride', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'a bride of (his) youth' (וכאשת נעורים תקבלנו).
- 3 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' swaps the placement of 'understanding' and 'wisdom'.
- 4 The WEBBE has 'confounded' (possibly following Cairo Genizah MS 'A') in place of 'put to shame'.
- 5 The NJB lacks the opening conjunction.
- 6 Cairo Genizah MS 'A' lacks 'crown of' before 'joy'.
- 7 In place of 'sinners', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'men of arrogance' (ואנשי זדון).
- 8 The NJB has 'call her to mind' in place of 'remember her'.

⁹ Οὐχ ὥραϊος αἶνος ἐν στόματι ἁμαρτωλοῦ,
 ὅτι οὐ παρὰ κυρίου ἀπεστάλη·
¹⁰ ἐν γὰρ σοφίᾳ ῥηθήσεται αἶνος,
 καὶ ὁ κύριος εὐοδώσει αὐτόν.
¹¹ μὴ εἴπῃς ὅτι Διὰ κύριον ἀπέστην·
 ἃ γὰρ ἐμίσησεν, οὐ ποιήσῃ.
¹² μὴ εἴπῃς ὅτι Αὐτός με ἐπλάνησεν·
 οὐ γὰρ χρεῖαν ἔχει ἄνδρὸς ἁμαρτωλοῦ.
¹³ πᾶν βδέλυγμα ἐμίσησεν ὁ κύριος,
 καὶ οὐκ ἔστιν ἀγαπητὸν τοῖς φοβουμένοις αὐτόν.
¹⁴ αὐτὸς ἐξ ἀρχῆς ἐποίησεν ἄνθρωπον
 καὶ ἀφῆκεν αὐτόν ἐν χειρὶ διαβουλίου αὐτοῦ.
¹⁵ ἐὰν θέλῃς, συντηρήσεις ἐντολὰς
 καὶ πίστιν ποιῆσαι εὐδοκίας.
¹⁶ παρέθηκεν σοι πῦρ καὶ ὕδωρ·
 οὗ ἐὰν θέλῃς, ἐκτενεῖς τὴν χειρὰ σου.

⁹ Praise is unseemly in a sinner's mouth,
 since it has not been sent from the Lord.
¹⁰ For, praise should be uttered only in wisdom,
 and the Lord himself then prompts it.
¹¹ Do not say, "The Lord was responsible for my sinning,"
 for he does not do what he hates.
¹² Do not say, "It was he who led me astray,"
 for he has no use for a sinner.
¹³ The Lord hates all that is foul,
 and no one who fears him will love it either.
¹⁴ He himself made human beings in the beginning,
 and left them free to make their own decisions.
¹⁵ If you choose, you will keep the commandments
 and so be faithful to his will.
¹⁶ He has set fire and water before you;
 put out your hand to whichever you prefer.

-
- ⁹ In Cairo Genizah MS 'A', the text of this verse (לֹא נִאֲתָה תְהִלָּה בְּפִי רָשָׁע כִּי לֹא מֵאֵל נִחְלָקָה לוֹ) is written in small letters between the preceding and following lines of the main text.
¹⁰ For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' reads 'and by her a proverb will be studied' (וּמִשְׁל בָּהּ יִלְמְדָנָה).
¹¹ 'He does not do' follows Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (לֹא עָשָׂה) and one Greek MS; the LXX has 'you ought not to do' (οὐ ποιήσῃ).
¹² God cannot be blamed for human sinfulness.
¹³ For 'the Lord', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has the 'triple-yod' (יִי) that represents the Divine Name.
¹⁴ This verse is often quoted in support of the doctrine of free will. The Cairo Genizah text, "he has handed him over to his enemy and left him to his own devices," (אֱלֹהִים מְבַרְאֵשׁטִית אֶבְרָא אֲדִיָּהם וּשְׁתִּיָּהוּ בִיד חֻתְפּוֹ וּיְתִנְהוּ בִיד יִצְרוֹ) seems more applicable, however, to the origin of evil. V. 15, on the other hand, really does affirm the freedom of the will. The word, יִצַּר, (used in v. 14) is a term meaning 'free choice', sometimes used in a good sense (Is 26:3, 1Ch 29:18) but usually referring to an evil inclination towards sin (Gn 6:5, 8:21, cf. 2Esd 4:30–31).
¹⁵ At the end of this verse, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds 'if you trust in him, you will also live' (אִם תֹּאמִין בּוֹ גַם אֶתָּה תְּחִיָּה).
¹⁶ 'Fire' and 'water' represent opposite extremes: fire here has no eschatological significance.

¹⁷ ἔναντι ἀνθρώπων ἡ ζωὴ καὶ ὁ θάνατος,
καὶ ὃ ἐὰν εὐδοκήσῃ, δοθήσεται αὐτῷ.
¹⁸ ὅτι πολλὴ ἡ σοφία τοῦ κυρίου·
ἰσχυρὸς ἐν δυναστείᾳ καὶ βλέπων τὰ πάντα,
¹⁹ καὶ οἱ ὀφθαλμοὶ αὐτοῦ ἐπὶ τοὺς φοβουμένους αὐτόν,
καὶ αὐτὸς ἐπιγνώσεται πᾶν ἔργον ἀνθρώπου.
²⁰ οὐκ ἐνετείλατο οὐδενὶ ἀσεβεῖν
καὶ οὐκ ἔδωκεν ἄνεσιν οὐδενὶ ἁμαρτάνειν.

¹⁷ A man has life and death before him;
whichever he prefers will be given him.
¹⁸ For vast is the wisdom of the Lord;
he is almighty and all seeing.
¹⁹ His eyes are on those who fear him
and he notes every act of man.
²⁰ He never commanded anyone to be godless
and he has given no one permission to sin.

¹⁷ The NJB has 'human being' in place of 'man'.

¹⁸ The divine attributes mentioned here reaffirm the point of view of vv. 11–13.

¹⁹ In place of 'act of man', the NJB has 'human action'.

²⁰ The Cairo Genizah MS 'A' text is longer, "He never commanded a man to sin and neither did he make men of falsehood to dream. And he has no mercy on him who works vanity and on him that discloses a secret." (לא צוה אנוש לחטא ולא החלים אנשי כזב: ולא מרחם על עושה שוא ועל מגלה סוד)

Σοφία Σιραχ 16

- ¹ Μὴ ἐπιθύμει τέκνων πλῆθος ἀχρήστων
μηδὲ εὐφραίνου ἐπὶ υἱοῖς ἀσεβέσιν·
- ² ἐὰν πληθύνωσιν, μὴ εὐφραίνου ἐπ' αὐτοῖς,
εἰ μὴ ἐστὶν φόβος κυρίου μετ' αὐτῶν.
- ³ μὴ ἐμπιστεύσης τῇ ζωῇ αὐτῶν
καὶ μὴ ἔπεχε ἐπὶ τὸ πλῆθος αὐτῶν·
κρείσσων γὰρ εἷς ἢ χίλιοι
καὶ ἀποθανεῖν ἄτεκνον ἢ ἔχειν τέκνα ἀσεβῆ.
- ⁴ ἀπὸ γὰρ ἐνὸς συνετοῦ συνοικισθήσεται πόλις,
φυλὴ δὲ ἀνόμων ἐρημωθήσεται.
- ⁵ Πολλὰ τοιαῦτα ἑώρακεν ὁ ὀφθαλμός μου,
καὶ ἰσχυρότερα τούτων ἀκήκοεν τὸ οὖς μου.
- ⁶ ἐν συναγωγῇ ἁμαρτωλῶν ἐκκαυθήσεται πῦρ,
καὶ ἐν ἔθνει ἀπειθεῖ ἐξεκαύθη ὀργή.
- ⁷ οὐκ ἐξιλάσατο περὶ τῶν ἀρχαίων γιγάντων,
οἳ ἀπέστησαν τῇ ἰσχύι αὐτῶν·

WISDOM OF SIRACH 16

- ¹ Do not long for a brood of worthless children,
and do not take pleasure in godless sons.
- ² If they multiply, take no pleasure in them,
unless the fear of the Lord lives among them.
- ³ Do not count on their having long life;
do not put too much faith in their number;
for, one can be better than a thousand,
and to die childless than to have godless children.
- ⁴ One person of sense can populate a city
but a race of lawless people will be destroyed.
- ⁵ My eyes have seen many such things;
me ears have heard things even more impressive.
- ⁶ Fire is kindled in a sinful society;
Retribution blazes in a rebellious nation.
- ⁷ God did not pardon the giants of old
who, confident in their strength, had rebelled.

WISDOM OF SIRACH 16

- ¹ In place of 'unprofitable', here following the LXX (ἀχρήστων), the NJB, following Cairo Genizah MS 'A', has 'worthless' (שוא).
- ² The NJB opens, "However many you have."
- ³ After 'number', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' adds 'for, they will not have a happy future' (כי לא תהיה להם אחרית טובה); and, after 'one', it adds 'doing good-will' (עושה רצון).
- ⁴ In place of 'person of sense', here following the LXX, Cairo Genizah MSS 'A' & 'B' have 'who fears the LORD' (ירא יי).
- ⁵ In Cairo Genizah MS 'B', an entire line has been erased after this verse.
- ⁶ Ben Sira here refers to the fate of Korah, Dathan, and Abiram (Nb 16).
- ⁷ On the 'giants', see Gn 6:4 (v. 7).

⁸ οὐκ ἐφείσατο περὶ τῆς παροικίας Λωτ,
 οὐς ἐβδελύξατο διὰ τὴν ὑπερηφανίαν αὐτῶν.
⁹ οὐκ ἠλέησεν ἔθνος ἀπωλείας
 τοὺς ἐξηρμένους ἐν ἁμαρτίαις αὐτῶν
¹⁰ καὶ οὕτως ἑξακοσίας χιλιάδας πεζῶν
 τοὺς ἐπισυναχθέντας ἐν σκληροκαρδίᾳ αὐτῶν.
¹¹ Καὶ ἢ εἷς σκληροτράχηλος,
 θαυμαστὸν τοῦτο εἰ ἀδωαθήσεται.
 ἔλεος γὰρ καὶ ὀργὴ παρ' αὐτῷ,
 δυνάστης ἐξιλασμῶν καὶ ἐκχέων ὀργήν.
¹² κατὰ τὸ πολὺ ἔλεος αὐτοῦ,
 οὕτως καὶ πολὺς ὁ ἔλεγχος αὐτοῦ.
 ἄνδρα κατὰ τὰ ἔργα αὐτοῦ κρινεῖ.
¹³ οὐκ ἐκφεύξεται ἐν ἀρπάγματι ἁμαρτωλός,
 καὶ οὐ μὴ καδυστερήσει ὑπομονὴ εὐσεβοῦς.
¹⁴ πάσῃ ἐλεημοσύνῃ ποιήσῃ τόπον,
 ἕκαστος κατὰ τὰ ἔργα αὐτοῦ εὐρήσει.
 יי הקשה את לב פרעה אשר לא ידעו: ¹⁰
 שמעשו ~ מגילין תחת השמים:

⁸ He did not spare the people with whom Lot lived;
 he abhorred them, rather, for their pride.
⁹ He was pitiless to the nation of perdition –
 those people who gloried in their sins –
¹⁰ as also to the six hundred thousand men on the march,
 who had banded together in their obstinacy.
¹¹ Even if there had been only one stubborn man,
 it would be a marvel if he escaped unpunished;
 for, mercy and wrath alike belong to the Lord,
 who is mighty to forgive and to pour out wrath.
¹² As great as is his mercy,
 so also is his severity;
 he judges a man as his deeds deserve.
¹³ The sinner will not escape with his ill-gotten gains,
 nor the patience of the devout go for nothing.
¹⁴ He takes note of every charitable action,
 and everyone is treated as he deserves.
¹⁵ *Yahweh made Pharaoh obstinate so he did not recognise him,
 to make his works known under heaven.*

⁸ Here, Ben Sira talks of the people of Sodom (see Ezk 16:49–50, Gn 19).

⁹ This verse speaks of the former people of Canaan.

¹⁰ The ‘six hundred thousand’ are the Israelites in the desert (Ex 12:37, Nb 11:21); they died in the desert and did not reach Canaan (Nb 14:20–33).

¹¹ The NJB opens the 2nd line, “it would have been amazing.”

¹² In place of ‘a man’, the NJB has ‘each person’.

¹³ The WEBBE has ‘perseverance’ in place of ‘patience’.

¹⁴ The 1st line here follows the LXX; Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’ has ‘Whoever does right, there is a wage for him’ (כל העושה צדקה יש לו שכר).

¹⁵ Vv. 15–16, here following Cairo Genizah MS ‘A’, the Peshitta, and the Greek 248 MS, are included in the NJB and NRSV only as a footnote.

רחמיו יראו לכל בריותיו
ואורו ושבתו חלק לבני אדם:

- ¹⁷ Μὴ εἴπῃς ὅτι Ἀπὸ κυρίου κρυβήσομαι,
καὶ ἐξ ὕψους τίς μου μνησθήσεται;
ἐν λαῷ πλείονι οὐ μὴ γνωσθῶ,
τίς γὰρ ἡ ψυχὴ μου ἐν ἀμετρήτῳ κτίσει;
¹⁸ ἰδοὺ ὁ οὐρανὸς καὶ ὁ οὐρανὸς τοῦ οὐρανοῦ,
ἄβυσσος καὶ γῆ ἐν τῇ ἐπισκοπῇ αὐτοῦ σαλευθήσονται.
¹⁹ ἅμα τὰ ὄρη καὶ τὰ θεμέλια τῆς γῆς
ἐν τῷ ἐπιβλέψαι εἰς αὐτὰ τρόμφ συσσεύονται.
²⁰ καὶ ἐπ' αὐτοῖς οὐ διανοηθήσεται καρδία,
καὶ τὰς ὁδοὺς αὐτοῦ τίς ἐνθυμηθήσεται;
²¹ καὶ καταιγίς, ἣν οὐκ ὄψεται ἄνθρωπος,
τὰ δὲ πλείονα τῶν ἔργων αὐτοῦ ἐν ἀποκρύφοις.
²² ἔργα δικαιοσύνης τίς ἀναγγελεῖ;
ἢ τίς ὑπομενεῖ; μακρὰν γὰρ ἡ διαθήκη.
²³ ἐλαττούμενος καρδίᾳ διανοεῖται ταῦτα,
καὶ ἀνὴρ ἄφρων καὶ πλανώμενος διανοεῖται μωρά.

- ¹⁶ *His mercy shows itself to all Creation;
he divided his light and his darkness with a plumb line.*
¹⁷ Do not say, "I shall hide from the Lord;
who is going to remember me up there?
I shall not be noticed among so many people;
what am I in the immensity of Creation?"
¹⁸ For see, the sky and the heavens above the sky,
the abyss and the earth shake at his visitation.
¹⁹ The mountains and earth's foundations alike
quail and tremble when he looks at them.
²⁰ But no human mind can grasp this.
Who keeps his movements in mind?
²¹ The storm wind itself is invisible,
and most of what he does goes undetected.
²² "Who will report whether justice has been done?
Who will be watching? The covenant is remote!"
²³ Such are the thoughts of the person of little sense,
stupid, misguided, cherishing his folly.

¹⁶ An alternative reading for 'with a plumb line' is 'among men'.

¹⁷ Ben Sira here alludes to the stories of Adam and Cain trying to hide from the sight of God (Gn 3:10, 4:9).

¹⁸ An alternative reading for the 1st line is, "Look at the heavens and the heaven of heavens."

¹⁹ In place of 'when he looks at them', Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has 'under the gaze of God' (בהביטו אליהם).

²⁰ Vv. 20–21 follow the LXX; Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has, "Nor does he take notice of me; who is concerned about my ways? Should I sin, no eye sees me; if I tell a hidden lie, who knows of it?" (גם עלי לא ישים לב ובדרכי מי יתבונן: אם חטאתי לא תראני עין או אם אכזב בכל סתר מי יודע)

²¹ Literally translated, the verse ends, "is amongst hidden things."

²² The objection here seems to be that retribution delays and is not certain. On the meaning of 'covenant' here, see #14:2. For the 2nd line, Cairo Genizah MS 'A' has, "What hope is there? For, the decree is far away ..." (יגידנו ותקות מה כי אצוק חוק)

²³ In this verse, Ben Sira expresses his judgement on the ideas expressed in vv. 17–22. The literal translation of 'sense' is 'heart'.

²⁴ Ἄκουσόν μου, τέκνον, καὶ μάθε ἐπιστήμην
καὶ ἐπὶ τῶν λόγων μου πρόσεχε τῇ καρδίᾳ σου·
²⁵ ἐκφανῶ ἐν σταθμῷ παιδείαν
καὶ ἐν ἀκριβείᾳ ἀπαγγελῶ ἐπιστήμην.
²⁶ Ἐν κρίσει κυρίου τὰ ἔργα αὐτοῦ ἀπ' ἀρχῆς,
καὶ ἀπὸ ποιήσεως αὐτῶν διέστειλεν μερίδας αὐτῶν.
²⁷ ἐκόσμησεν εἰς αἰῶνα τὰ ἔργα αὐτοῦ
καὶ τὰς ἀρχὰς αὐτῶν εἰς γενεὰς αὐτῶν·
οὔτε ἐπείνασαν οὔτε ἐκοπίασαν
καὶ οὐκ ἐξέλιπον ἀπὸ τῶν ἔργων αὐτῶν·
²⁸ ἕκαστος τὸν πλησίον αὐτοῦ οὐκ ἐξέθλιψεν,
καὶ ἕως αἰῶνος οὐκ ἀπειθήσουσιν τοῦ ῥήματος αὐτοῦ.
²⁹ καὶ μετὰ ταῦτα κύριος εἰς τὴν γῆν ἐπέβλεψεν
καὶ ἐνέπλησεν αὐτὴν τῶν ἀγαθῶν αὐτοῦ·
³⁰ ψυχῇ παντὸς ζώου ἐκάλυψεν τὸ πρόσωπον αὐτῆς,
καὶ εἰς αὐτὴν ἡ ἀποστροφή αὐτῶν.

²⁴ Listen to me, my child, and learn knowledge,
and give your whole mind to my words.
²⁵ I shall expound discipline methodically
and proclaim knowledge with precision.
²⁶ When God created his works in the beginning,
he assigned their boundaries from their making.
²⁷ He determined his works for all time,
from their origins to their distant generations.
They know neither hunger nor weariness,
and they never desert their duties.
²⁸ Not one has ever got in the way of another,
and they will never disobey his word.
²⁹ Then the Lord looked upon the earth
and filled it with his blessings.
³⁰ He covered its surface with every kind of animal
and, to it, they will return.

²⁴ The scribe is speaking here, not wisdom personified.

²⁵ The WEBBE reads, "I will impart instruction with precision, and declare knowledge exactly."

²⁶ '(God) created' is conjectural, following Cairo Genizah MS 'A' (כברא אל); the LXX has 'judged'. MS 'A' ends in the middle of this verse, finishing with an upper bar about 4 or 5 letters wide after the last word (חיהם).

²⁷ For the first 2 lines, here following the NJB, the NRSV has, "He arranged his works in an eternal order, and their dominion (elements) for all generations."

²⁸ Ben Sira is here referring to the regular motions of the heavenly bodies.

²⁹ The NJB has 'good things' in place of 'blessings'.

³⁰ The WEBBE has the verb in the 2nd line in the present tense.

*The annotation and parallel formatting of Chs 17-51 is currently 'in progress'
and will hopefully be completed during the course of 2025.*